

•

second row, second seat

Ashutosh Vishwakarma

Contents

1	Entry	1
2	Interaction	7
3	Introspection	13
4	Outcast	16
5	Liminal	21
6	Off Guard	25
7	Retort	29
8	Masks	32
9	Refraction	37
10	Homecoming	44
11	Lane	49
12	Parallels	53

13 Search	58
14 Convergence	64
15 Discord	68
16 Ingratitude	73
17 Ebb	75

Entry

It was the first day after summer vacation, and June still clung to the air like a heavy blanket. The fans on the classroom ceiling dragged themselves in slow circles, pushing warm air from one corner to another. Shirts stuck to backs, ties tightened for morning assembly still refused to loosen their grip on sweaty necks. Seventh graders filled the room with chatter. A month apart felt like a year at their age. Everyone had stories to tell and voices seemed to rise from every bench—except the last one, where Shiva sat with his usual companions, Vijay and Rajveer. The three of them—self-declared Tridev—leaned close, talking as if the rest of the class didn’t exist.

“So, where did you go this time?” Shiva asked, pulling at his tie until the knot finally gave up.

Vijay grinned. “To my mama’s place. He has a big fishpond now. I even went with him for a fish catch. They use those huge nets, you know? One pull and you get hundreds. He’s doing well—government job, side business... everything.”

Rajveer nodded. “Fisheries is good money. My uncle also has ponds. People earn a lot.”

Vijay puffed up a little. “And my elder uncle might become village

head this time. He even lets villagers fish for free sometimes. Gains goodwill that way.”

Shiva listened, nodding, though something tight curled in his chest. He had nothing grand like this to share—no ponds, no wealthy relatives, no election-bound uncles. That small pinch of insignificance, the kind he never admitted to anyone, settled quietly inside him. So he reached for the one thing he did have—knowledge.

“I read that the economy’s improving,” he said. “Lot of privatization now. The government is pushing business growth.”

Vijay snapped his fingers. “Oh! I also read about INS Vikramaditya. India got it from Russia. It’s massive! Like a whole city floating.”

“What does it do?” Rajveer asked.

“It carries fighter jets,” Vijay said dramatically. “Just imagine—planes taking off from the sea!”

Before anyone could reply, the classroom door swung open. In one motion, every student scrambled back to their seats. Books snapped shut, whispers died mid-sentence. “Good morning, Ma’am!” the class chorused. Ms. Sneha entered with her attendance register tucked under her arm. Her smile was warm—the kind that made even the boring subjects feel interesting. Shiva liked her classes. She explained Social Science like it was some story unfolding around them, not just printed text to memorize. She began calling out names. One by one, students stood and answered. “Present, Ma’am.” “Present, Ma’am.” The rhythm was familiar, almost comforting, even with fifty-plus students in the room. Shiva wasn’t paying much attention—until a soft voice interrupted the routine.

“My name is Gauri Mishra. I studied previously in the city.” The voice reached Shiva soft and clear, and something in it caught him mid-thought. Who is she? His head lifted before he even realized it. She stood in the second row, first bench, her chin slightly raised as if she wasn’t entirely sure she wanted to be here. Pink frameless spectacles rested neatly on her nose. Two ponytails fell over her shoulders, tied tight and perfectly even. Something about her speech—clear, calm, practiced—made the whole room seem quieter to Shiva. The heat, the

fans, even Vijay's previous excitement... everything faded a little. He kept watching. Not staring, exactly—just drawn in, as if she were a new word in a book he wanted to understand. The rest of the class buzzed on, but Shiva barely heard any of it. The period ended quicker than he wanted. When the bell rang, he almost jolted upright. "I'll be back," he muttered to his friends and immediately walked toward the front benches. He didn't dare speak to Gauri. Even looking at her too long felt like breaking some rule. Instead, he stopped beside Divya, who sat next to her.

"Hi, Divya. How are you?"

Divya raised an eyebrow. "So you remembered I exist?"

Shiva laughed awkwardly. "Hey—those two kept talking. I meant to come earlier."

Her teasing softened into a smile. She clearly understood why he had suddenly found the front benches so interesting.

On the second bench, Mohit sat hunched over his notebook. Shiva tapped the desk. "Mohit, can you move a bit? I need to sit here."

Mohit brightened instantly. "Sure!"

Shiva sat down behind Gauri. Not close enough to draw attention—just close enough to see the tiny strands of hair escaping her ponytail, the slight tilt of her head when she read something, the city-girl confidence in the way she straightened her posture. For the first time that day, the heat didn't bother him anymore.

The next period was Science. The moment Mr. Arvind Rai stepped into the room, the class rose again in a messy chorus. "Good morning, sir!" Shiva usually brightened at the sight of Mr. Arvind. Science was his subject—his territory. But today his mind was elsewhere, drifting around the first bench where Gauri sat, her ponytails perfectly still even in the warm breeze from the windows. He didn't even notice the commotion until a sharp voice cracked through his thoughts.

"Shiva! You, too, haven't completed the homework?"

The class froze. Mr. Arvind's eyes were fixed on him, brows pulled tight. Shiva blinked. Around him, several students were standing with notebooks open. His stomach dropped.

“Were you playing all summer?” Mr. Arvind demanded. “Why is your homework incomplete?”

“No, sir!” Shiva shot up immediately. “I—I did my homework. All of it. Even made the diagram on chart paper. It’s... in my bag.”

A ripple of murmurs spread. Someone snickered. And just for a moment, as Shiva glanced ahead, he caught Gauri turning slightly—her lips curled in a quiet, teasing smile. A smile meant to mock him. Yet it somehow made his heart jump.

“So you forgot to bring your bag?” Mr. Arvind’s voice softened into a mocking tone.

“No, sir! It’s just... I changed my seat.”

Shiva hurried across the room to the last bench, fumbling with his bag. He pulled out the neatly finished homework and the chart paper. Mr. Arvind followed, checked the work, then signed it.

“Since you’ve changed your seat, sit here now,” he ordered, pointing to the last bench he had his bag on.

“Yes, sir,” Shiva replied, settling down as the shame of it prickled over his skin. He kept his gaze low. Great first impression, he thought bitterly. What must she think now? Some careless boy who forgets his homework? I’m the topper... she won’t know that. He risked a tiny glance at her. But she was already looking ahead, attentive, ready for the lesson. Whatever expression she’d had earlier was gone, replaced by calm focus.

Mr. Arvind began explaining the chapter on the water cycle. Pages flipped. Pens clicked. Slowly, Shiva’s embarrassment loosened its grip as the lesson pulled him in. Water moving through clouds and mountains... traveling for centuries... shaping life, shaping earth. He imagined rivers carving their way through stone, raindrops falling before humans ever existed. The thought soothed him—water had patience, purpose. Maybe he could too.

By the time the bell rang after four periods, the classroom transformed instantly. The “recess bell” didn’t ring—the class exploded. Benches rattled as kids shot up like springs. Some rushed to the washroom, some sprinted to the playground, and some clustered around the

lunches. Shiva didn't bring lunch anymore. Carrying a tiffin felt childish, like something kids in lower classes still did. Instead, he joined the familiar wandering tribe—those who survived on bites stolen from friends' lunchboxes. He followed Vijay and Rajveer, hopping booth-to-booth like food pirates. Aryan's lunchbox was the biggest treasure. He always brought the good stuff—maggi, sandwiches, aloo-paratha. Naturally, it disappeared within seconds.

Aryan stared at the empty box like a man betrayed. "I swear I'm not bringing lunch from tomorrow," he muttered. "I barely get two bites of my own food."

From the side, Suraj grinned. "Why? Is suji running out in your shop?"

Laughter burst across the group. Even Shiva cracked up as they drifted toward the next target. When the raid was over, Suraj opened his own steel lunchbox with exaggerated hope—only for the group to collectively groan.

"Seriously? Karela?" Aryan recoiled. "Who brings bitter gourd on the first day? Want us to celebrate with poison?"

Suraj shrugged happily, already chewing. "I don't have a suji shop like you, Aryan. We have this. Eat if you want—I don't stop anyone."

Aryan walked away with a smug look on his face. Shiva wiped tears of laughter from his eyes.

Just then, Vijay slid back into the room, drifting on the dusty floor as if performing some stunt. "Let's go to the ground!" he declared.

"Isn't it boiling hot outside?" Aryan asked.

Rajveer smirked. "Why scared? Sun will burn you? Don't be like girls hiding from the heat."

With that unbeatable logic, the boys exchanged glances—then gave in. Shiva, Vijay, Aryan, and Rajveer headed out into the sunlit corridor, laughter trailing behind them like shadows stretching in the afternoon light.

The final bell rang, and just like that, the day dissolved into the familiar rush of feet and voices. Shiva walked out with the seventh-grade boys, a strange mix of joy and nervous energy pulsing through him.

He had met his friends again, shared laughter, stolen lunch bites—but Gauri’s face kept flashing before his eyes, quick and bright, and every time the memory surfaced a smile slipped onto his face without warning. But school was over now. Time to go home. Two long columns—girls on one side, boys on the other—began marching down the school street like Roman legions called to formation. Teachers stood at intervals, trying to hold the fragile order together. Younger classes led the way, the older ones drifting forward behind them in slow waves. School vans filled one after another, swallowing lines of students. The quiet discipline of the morning was replaced with noise from every direction—shouts, laughter, horns, sandals scraping the dusty ground. Ms. Sneha finally instructed the seventh-grade girls to move, then the boys. Shiva joined the tail end of the line.

He climbed into the school van—“the magic,” as everyone called it—and slipped into the back seat, the one that could fit three. It was his favorite spot. From there he could see the road stretching behind them, and it was where Krishna, a ninth grader he admired, usually sat. They weren’t exactly neighbors, but their houses were close enough that Shiva felt a natural fondness for him. As the van rolled out of the parking lot and merged onto the highway, Shiva barely registered the traffic. His mind replayed the moment in science class again and again. Had he ruined his first impression? Did she think he was careless? Foolish? He stared out of the back window, watching other school vans pass by, buses packed with older students, and clusters of seniors riding bicycles with practiced ease. And then, suddenly, his gaze froze. Across the highway, walking alone with a handkerchief held over her face to block the dust and heat—was Gauri. Shiva’s spine stiffened. Their eyes met for the briefest heartbeat through the moving window. Just a second. Maybe less. But she looked at him. And he looked back. Then she lowered her head, and the moment slipped away as the van moved ahead. Shiva leaned back slowly, weightless, giddy, as though he had just won something enormous. Over the moon. For the first time all day, he wasn’t thinking about homework or embarrassment or anything else. She had seen him. And that was enough.

Interaction

The second seat of the second row had quietly become Shiva's place. Vijay followed him there without question—Vijay behind Divya, and Shiva directly behind Gauri. Yet Shiva still hadn't spoken a single word to her. It surprised even him. He was usually effortless with people, the kind who could strike up a conversation with anyone. Talking to girls had never made him nervous. But this time, something invisible held him back. What would she think of me? The question circled endlessly in his head. Gauri carried herself differently—confident, composed, almost distant. She barely spoke, except to Divya beside her. Shiva watched her from behind, wondering how she would react if he suddenly spoke. What if she brushed him off? Worse—what if she smiled politely and turned away, as if he didn't matter at all? And even if he did speak... what would he say? Thoughts crowded his mind, one after another, until he finally gave up and turned his attention to the blackboard, his books, his friends—anything that might quiet the noise inside his head. But Gauri refused to stay out of it. Sometimes, as she leaned forward during class, her ponytails would slip back and brush against the edge of his notebook. Each time it happened, his pen paused mid-word, his thoughts drifting helplessly

toward her again. Sitting behind her had been a mistake, he decided. From another row, at least he could steal a glance—catch a glimpse of her face. Now, she was closer than ever, yet somehow farther away. The old line drifted into his mind without invitation: darkness beneath the lamp. It felt painfully true.

On that day, the Math teacher was absent. On such days, it was customary for a replacement teacher to arrive—usually someone borrowed from another wing of the school. Until then, the class was left to its own devices. Shiva, the class monitor, took it upon himself to “manage” things. He walked up and down the aisles with an air of quiet importance. Not the tyrant kind of monitor—the ones who scribbled names on the blackboard and acted like miniature dictators—but the friendly sort. No threats. No punishments. No shouting. Students moved from bench to bench freely. Conversations floated across the room. Shiva himself had no real reason to be at half the desks he visited, but walking around felt right. After all, this was what being monitor looked like. Still, it wasn’t chaos. There was laughter, gossip, shifting seats—but no screaming, no desks overturned. Shiva’s only rule was simple: if a teacher walked in, the class should look like a class. And eventually, one did. She was from the junior wing—one of those teachers who taught kindergarten students, maybe up to third standard at most. Shiva noticed her just as she reached the doorway. Oh, no. Not her, he thought. The moment she stepped inside, the class snapped into silence. Students hurried back to their seats as if someone had pulled an invisible string. Shiva slid back into the third row, settling into the seat of the friend he had been talking to moments earlier. The room fell unnaturally quiet—like a tired animal collapsing after a long run. No one spoke. From beside Shiva, a boy leaned in and whispered, “Why don’t you ask her for a quiz during this free period?” Shiva sighed. “Do you really think she’ll agree?” “What else are we going to do for the whole period?” the boy pressed. Shiva glanced toward the teacher, then back at the class. Should I ask? he wondered. Quizzes were his strength. He liked them. He prepared for them. Not only that, but he and a few others had memorized almost the entire

Lucent's General Knowledge book—dates, facts, capitals—just in case moments like these appeared out of nowhere. And now, one had. Shiva straightened slightly, still unsure, but the thought had already rooted itself in his mind.

“Ma’am, can we have a quiz, please?” Shiva asked, his voice soft, almost pleading. The teacher paused and looked around, scanning the room as if trying to locate the disturbance. Shiva quickly stood up, saving her the trouble. “Ma’am, please,” he added. “We still have a lot of time.” She adjusted her spectacles, unimpressed. “I don’t think anyone would even join,” she said calmly. “Most of you are busy anyway. It’s better to do your homework while you have free time.” “But ma’am,” Shiva persisted, “we don’t have any homework. It’s only the second period. Many of us want to have a small round.” A sudden chorus erupted from Shiva’s row. “Yes, ma’am!” The teacher hesitated for a moment, then sighed lightly. “Alright,” she said. “Those who want a quiz—raise your hands.” Instantly, almost every boy shot his hand into the air. A few girls followed, glancing at one another before committing. Those already participating began nudging their neighbors, whispering encouragement, urging more hands up. Within seconds, the decision was obvious. The quiz was inevitable.

“No, ma’am. They’ll disturb us. I’m reading right now.” Gauri’s voice cut cleanly through the room. Shiva blinked, momentarily caught off guard. Reading? Right now? He glanced around—no books open, nothing urgent in sight. “But ma’am,” he said, turning back to the teacher, “everyone wants to play.” The teacher considered this, then spoke firmly. “Alright. Those who want to have a quiz may do so, but there must be no nuisance. Those who want to read will read. No one disturbs anyone.” “They always say that, ma’am,” Gauri replied at once. Her voice was steady, edged with resolve. “They make a lot of noise and disturb everyone.” A few girls nodded in agreement. “Stop her, Shiva,” the boy beside him whispered. “She won’t let us have even a small quiz. Who does she think she is?” Shiva exhaled. So be it, he thought. Duty to the comrades. “They’re just scared to lose, ma’am,” he said, his tone light but pointed. The words landed

harder than he expected. Gauri straightened in her seat and turned halfway around. “Who do you think you are?” she shot back. “You act like you’re so smart—but you’re not.” The class fell silent. Shiva said nothing. Bragging had never been his way, and defending himself now felt unnecessary. He could feel eyes on him—from every corner of the room. “What is this behavior?” the teacher snapped. “What is your name?” “Gauri, ma’am,” she replied, her voice controlled but tight. “Gauri,” the teacher said, each syllable heavy with warning, “if you don’t want to join, you may continue your work. But this is not how you speak. Apologize to Shiva.” For a moment, Gauri stayed still. Then, without looking at him, she said softly, “Sorry.” Her face flushed red as she turned back to her desk and sat down, shoulders stiff with anger and frustration. The air in the classroom remained tense—charged, unsettled—as if something fragile had just been cracked.

The quiz commenced with the teacher pulling out a scrap of paper to keep score, dividing the class into two halves — two rows each—with Shiva and Gauri standing in opposite camps, though it hardly seemed at first that she intended to participate at all. Questions began flying back and forth, and Shiva answered many with ease, supported by the usual quiz enthusiasts, while his team’s secret weapon—a boy famously nicknamed Inventor for his uncanny memory of obscure innovations and their creators—left the opposing side helpless with questions about forgotten inventors of washing machines, automatic rifles, and countless other oddities, pushing the score steadily upward. Then, unexpectedly, Gauri stood up from the other side and asked, “What is the full form of ALU?” Shiva almost laughed to himself—wasn’t this taught in third grade?—and replied instantly, “Arithmetic and Logic Unit,” finishing with a faint, taunting smile as another point was added and Gauri sat down in silence, visibly embarrassed. By the time the bell rang, the gap was humiliating—the opposing team hadn’t even managed half of Shiva’s score—and though it was a clear victory, Shiva found no real joy in it, his thoughts already spiraling elsewhere: Was it worth it? Had he angered her beyond repair? Had he embarrassed her too much? The thrill of winning faded quickly, drowned beneath a growing guilt that

refused to quiet down.

As usual, school ended, yet Shiva never found the courage to speak to her. Their very first interaction had gone so wrong that it only deepened the distance he already felt, and by the time he reached home, guilt and remorse clung to him like dust after a long walk. After lunch, he sat beside his Nani as the afternoon settled into the house. He had grown up here, in his grandmother's house, ever since he was old enough for a proper school; his parents' village lay too far from any worth attending, so Nani and Mama had raised him, and his mother had become someone who visited mostly with the festivals. She broke the silence first. "Ramujagir's tractor will come to our field today for ploughing. You go and keep an eye on it—these days they've grown lazy. A few rounds on the topsoil, corners untouched, and they leave." Shiva asked quietly, "What time did he say?" "Five in the evening," she replied. "Alright, I'll go. Where is Mama? Isn't he coming?" "No, he's gone to town for some work," she said, shaking her head. "People today don't know how much hard work farming takes. Others in the village are growing vegetables, selling in the market, doing well. Your Nana served all those years in a government job and never once gave up the farming. In his prime he would plough the fields before dawn with the oxen, then still reach work on time." Her voice softened into a sigh as they sat together in the hall, old family photographs lining the walls, the afternoon drifting past in comfortable quiet.

While sitting there, Shiva noticed two familiar figures pass along the road in front of his house—Rohan and Manoj, village friends and neighbors—waving exaggeratedly for him to join them. He got up, crossed the yard, and met them beneath a nearby bael tree. "Are you coming for the cricket match today?" Rohan asked. "I have to go to the fields," Shiva replied briskly, leaning against the thin trunk. "Ramujagir is coming to plough." Manoj plucked a leaf and began stripping its hard vein with his teeth. "When will you be back? You can join even if it's late. We'll play one or two matches till then." "He told me to come at five," Shiva said, sinking his weight further into the tree. "He's ploughing Tedhiya—it's not very big. Should take about

an hour.” Rohan nodded. “Alright. We’re going to call the others and will leave by four. We’ll catch you there, then? At least come—don’t make excuses this time.” The three of them leaned against the tree, slowly curling around it like snakes around a sandalwood trunk, when a voice called out from the house. “Shiva!” “Coming, Nani,” he called back, straightening himself. He walked away with steady steps, leaving the tree quiet again in the afternoon heat. Back inside, he sat beside Nani once more, resting his head in her lap, his eyes drifting toward the clock. Her soft fingers moved gently through his hair, and a deep sense of peace settled over him. Slowly, his eyelids grew heavy, and he drifted into sleep.

“Bhaiya . . . bhaiya . . . wake up.” Rahul — Mama’s younger son — was shaking his arm gently, his voice tugging him out of sleep. Shiva stirred on the same sofa where he had dozed off earlier. From the inner gallery, where Nani sat on her small daybed, her voice followed, firm with concern. “It’s already five, Shiva. The tractor must have reached the fields by now.” He pushed himself upright, sleep still clinging to his eyes. “Bring the cycle,” he said calmly, and headed toward the backyard alley. After washing his face and having a cup of tea, he set off for the fields.

Returning home late from the cricket match with his friends, he had dinner and went straight to his bed. He opened his books, but his mind refused to stay with the pages, drifting instead into a tangle of thoughts. Sleep wouldn’t come. After a while, realizing he hadn’t read a single word, he pushed the books aside and lay back, letting his gaze wander the dark ceiling. Wide awake after a day crowded with events, he stared on, thoughts whispering endlessly. I shouldn’t talk to her. She doesn’t want to talk to me at all. I don’t want to upset her even more. Today was already enough. The night held still around him, and his thoughts kept wandering.

Introspection

Shiva came to class and took his usual place—the second bench in the second row—but this time he was unusually quiet. He didn’t speak to Vijay or Rajveer, not even in passing. Ms. Sneha went over the answers from the chapter they had just finished, and he copied them down without a word. The loose strands from Gauri’s ponytails still brushed the edge of his notebook now and then, but each time, he shifted it away, creating a careful distance. The period dragged on, and when the bell finally announced recess, Shiva slipped out of the classroom without waiting for anyone, sidestepping the familiar rush and noise, and stopped in the corridor. After a while, Divya joined him. “What happened?” she asked. “You’re unusually quiet today.” “Nothing... nothing,” Shiva replied quickly. “It was just a bit hot inside, so I came out for some air.” “Oh, don’t hide,” Divya said gently. “I know everything.” “What everything? I don’t know what you’re talking about,” he said, forcing a faint smile. “Believe it or not, I understand,” she continued. “Just don’t take it too seriously. She’s always a little rude.” Shiva gripped the corridor railing, warm from the sun. “She isn’t angry with you at all,” Divya added. Just then, Rajveer walked up. “Why are you two standing here?” he asked. “Nothing,”

Divya replied softly, a sigh slipping into her voice. “Just waiting for recess to end.” “Isn’t today the selection for the morning assembly prayer group?” Rajveer asked. “Yes,” Divya said, her eyes lighting up. “I almost forgot. I think Gauri will join it.” Without saying anything, Shiva turned back toward the classroom, his head lowered as he returned to his seat.

Then came the uneasy moments before the final bell—the time when the class teacher arrived to sign everyone’s homework diary. Shiva’s heart sank. He hadn’t written homework for a single subject, yet the signature was unavoidable. He leaned toward Vijay. “Have you written your homework in the diary?” he asked quickly. “No,” Vijay replied with a grin, nodding toward Divya, who was busy filling out both her own diary and his. “Oh. Great,” Shiva muttered, defeated. Divya soon stood up and walked to the podium with both diaries in hand. Shiva hesitated, then glanced toward Gauri. She was already absorbed in a book. For a moment, he almost gave up—but then, summoning what little courage he had, he raised his trembling hand and gently tapped her shoulder. She turned sharply, surprise flashing across her eyes as she looked at him. “Have you completed your diary today?” he asked softly. Without a word, she slid her diary onto his desk. “Yes... return it quickly,” she said. “Sure. Thank you,” Shiva replied, picking it up at once. He began copying carefully, letter by letter, as if precision might somehow steady his nerves. A few minutes later, he placed the diary back on her desk. “Thank you,” he said, then added, almost involuntarily, “Your handwriting is really nice.” She paused. “No one says that. You might be the first,” she replied. “No, I mean the way you write ‘S’” he said with a small smile. “It’s very curved.” “Oh... thanks,” she said, already turning back to her book, the moment slipping away as quietly as it had come.

He boarded his van as he always did. Across the highway, Gauri walked on the opposite side, a handkerchief held lightly to her face—a sight that had quietly turned into a ritual. She never really looked at him, perhaps a passing glance on rare days, nothing more. Still, staying at home had begun to feel unbearable. Her presence lingered

in his thoughts long after she disappeared from view.

Back home, he ate lunch and slept through the afternoon, exhaustion mixing with restlessness. As the sun began to soften, he grabbed his bicycle, slipped his Micromax keypad phone and earphones into his pocket, and headed out, casually mentioning at home that he was going to check on the crops—crops that didn't really exist. The countryside, as always, held its quiet treasures: peace suspended in the air, unbroken and generous.

He left his bicycle beneath a tree in a bagh, a small orchard with only a handful of mango trees and a dense stand of bamboo along one edge. It lay far from both village and home—the nearest house more than two kilometers away. In the distance, the sun sank slowly, painting the sky in deep reds and spreading its glow across the trees. Below his fields stretched a dry riverbed, bare as bone for now, waiting for the monsoon to swell it into a river that would feel like a sea in its own right. Occasionally, herds of cows and buffaloes emerged on the horizon, moving lazily across the land. Everything felt quiet—serene, almost unreal—peaceful in a way that felt nothing short of magical.

How vast this world is, he thought. In all his life, he had barely stepped beyond the familiar—just the stretch between his own home and his mama's village, seventy or eighty kilometers apart, a place he had known since childhood. Two places. That was all. What lay beyond that—what was hidden inside those distant villages? How would it feel to wander through their narrow alleys, to live a life entirely unknown to him? His gaze settled on a tiny cluster of houses across the riverbank, no more than specks against the fading light, and his thoughts drifted with them.

Then, inevitably, his mind circled back to Gauri. Does it really matter if she talks to me or not? he wondered. And even if she did—what then? Shouldn't I be focusing on myself? One day, he would see the whole world. He knew that. Why should he anchor himself here, weighed down by someone else's opinions, when there was so much waiting beyond this river, beyond this village, beyond himself?

Outcast

It was a gentle morning. The sun was still rising, far from its full strength, and the sky lay heavy with scattered dark clouds. The backyard was damp, the narrow alley slick with moisture—clear signs that it had rained during the night. Shiva remembered half-waking to the sound of rainfall tapping against the world beyond his window, then drifting back into sleep. He rose early, bathed, and stepped into the veranda with a cup of tea warming his hands. Nani was already there, seated on her low stool, laying out clothes for her bath. “Giridhar, won’t be coming today to deliver milk,” she said softly. “His son will be at home instead. Someone needs to go and collect it.” Shiva took a careful sip of the hot tea. “It’s still more than an hour before the school van comes,” Nani continued. “Finish your tea and go get the milk.” “Okay... I’ll go,” Shiva said, then hesitated. “But I don’t know where his house is.” “It’s near the Samaya Mata temple,” she replied, adjusting her saree. “Just go there and ask anyone for Giridhar’s house. They’ll show you.” “How much milk should I take?” he asked, sitting down on the sofa and picking up yesterday’s newspaper from the side table. “Two liters, my son. Don’t you remember?” she said, glancing at him while holding the freshly ironed saree. “Take the vessel—he’ll

measure it exactly. And tell him the milk has been thinner since last month.” “Sure,” Shiva nodded. “And don’t drink just tea,” she added firmly, concern slipping into her voice. “Take some namkeen from the almirah.” She paused, looking at the saree again. “You ironed this nicely last night. See how smooth the edges are.” A faint smile crossed her face. “If my legs hadn’t failed me, I’d still be ironing everything myself—mine and your Nana’s. Even back then, with that coal iron.” “What are you worrying about while I’m here?” Shiva said lightly, smiling as he flipped the newspaper to the global news page. “I can iron all your clothes in an hour now. I’m much faster than when I started.”

He got out as soon as he finished the tea. RCC roads had been laid throughout the village, but mud would still find its way during the rain. He crossed the main street and turned twice on narrower and narrower lanes. At one point he came across a cow being bound to a pole just adjacent to the narrow lane hardly a meter and half wide. Dung was all over the place. Rain had made it worse—the cow had likely trampled through it, churning the dung into a thick slurry that mixed with the mud and spread across the lane. Shiva was in his slippers. He couldn’t get through this, he thought—the muck would cling to his soles and feet. He paused, looking for a way around it. Someone must have crossed this mess before him; there had to be a trail. While he was still searching, a man arrived from the other side, staring at Shiva from afar as he approached. He just came and crossed through the mud with no issues. Shiva felt embarrassed. Probably he might be thinking of him as some kind of city brat with foolish tantrums, he thought to himself. Without paying much attention he walked straight through it all. A mix of mud and dung got all over his feet; even walking became difficult in those slippery slippers. But at last, passing all the hurdles he reached the temple mentioned by Nani. It stood on the eastern edge of the village, the riverbed beyond it and farms stretching to the horizon after that. Small traces of water were visible in the distance—the riverbed had probably begun to fill.

Looking around, he saw women busy with cattle, some tending to cows, others herding goats. On a few porches, girls—about his age or

younger—were crouched near mud hearths, preparing for the day's first meal. Thin streams of smoke already curled up from several houses, dissolving into the damp morning air. It felt different from his own home. They had a mud hearth too, but it was lit only on festivals; on ordinary days, the gas stove did the work. Here, everything ran on routine and necessity. Everyone moved with purpose, like parts of a well-worn machine, each absorbed in their task. He didn't recognize a single face. A quiet hesitation crept through him. Whom should he ask? What if he was standing in the wrong part of the village altogether? The thought of asking for Giridhar—and being laughed at for not knowing his way around the very village he had grown up in—made his steps slow, his confidence thin.

"Aren't you Raghu's nephew?" a female voice came from behind. He turned sharply to see a woman holding a worn out plastic tub against her waist filled with cattle fodder. "Yes... I am." It felt as though he was seeing this woman for the first time in his life. Yet somehow she had recognized him. "What are you doing here?" she asked politely while her gaze fell on the handled vessel in his hand. "So, you came for milk." she continued. "Are you receiving milk from Giridhar?" she asked while pulling the sliding tub up on her waist. "Yes, I came for his house." he replied with gratitude and gentleness. She pointed towards a group of houses barely fifty meters away saying "Go to that green house with the cow next to it. That's Giridhar's house." "Okay... okay, aunty," he replied, still dragging his slippery slippers along the muddy lane.

He reached the house quickly. Two adult men were seated on a cot nearby. "You got quite late—but at least you came," one of them remarked, stretching out his arm to take the vessel from Shiva's hand. "It's very muddy in the narrow lanes," Shiva replied, offering it as a reasonable excuse. "Which way did you come from?" the man asked, a note of concern entering his voice. "Did you pass through the lane near Rambihari's shop?" "Yes, that way," Shiva answered plainly. "You should've turned at the second cut from the main street. The road there is cleaner, fewer turns," the man said, then glanced toward a

young girl wiping chairs on the veranda. "These goat herders have ruined that lane—nothing but filth all the way." Shiva stood quietly, unsure how to respond. "How much should I measure?" the girl asked, taking the vessel. "Two liters," the man replied. She carried it inside. "Sit," the man said, shifting to clear space on the cot. "Which class are you in?" "Seventh," Shiva replied, lowering himself slowly onto the edge. "Good. Study with dedication and hard work—you'll make all of us proud one day." Shiva offered a faint, uncertain smile. "My son studies too," the man continued, pride lighting his eyes. "Second class, MKS School. Very good at English. I don't understand a single word, but he reads fluently—or so it seems to me. The school isn't like your English-medium one, but I'm doing my best. I'll support him for as long as he wants to study." Shiva listened in silence, still as stone. The girl returned with the vessel filled with milk and handed it to him. Shiva stood up and said, sincerity softening his voice, "Alright, uncle. I'll come again sometime. I have to catch my school van." He walked away quietly, the weight of the conversation lingering long after the sound of his footsteps faded.

He returned home, placed the milk vessel in the kitchen. From there, he went straight to his room and changed into his school uniform. A few minutes later, he came back to the kitchen, quickly finished the breakfast Mami had prepared, and slung his bag over his shoulders before stepping out into the veranda. Nani was lighting incense sticks for the morning prayer, her hands moving slowly as thin streams of smoke rose toward the sun. "Why don't you take your lunch?" she asked, her voice carrying both care and firmness. "I've already had breakfast," Shiva replied, edging toward the exit. "I don't feel hungry in class anyway. And the lunch break is very short." He was about to leave when her voice grew sharper. "Do you think I don't know how school works just because I didn't go one myself?" she said. "Children take lunch every day. You'll only burn your blood with hunger. At least take some biscuits—I've kept them on the table." Shiva stopped, turned back at once, picked up the packet of biscuits, and hurried out to the road again.

Within moments, the school van appeared and came to a halt beside him. He climbed into his usual back seat and stared out quietly as his home slowly disappeared behind the turning wheels.

Liminal

School had become the place Shiva waited for every day. It gave him an identity—topper, class monitor—and now, Gauri. He continued sitting on the second bench, directly behind her, and copying from her diary had quietly turned into a routine. “Hey... um...” he fumbled one day, hesitating long enough for both girls to turn toward him. “What was your name again?” he asked, sheepish. Both of them burst out laughing. “Gauri, you idiot,” Divya said, still chuckling. “How many times have you already asked?” “It just... slips from my head,” Shiva replied, tapping his forehead lightly. “Remember it properly this time,” Gauri said, a soft smile lifting her face. “If needed, write it a hundred times in a notebook—like kindergarten kids do to learn words.” That question had become his icebreaker ever since he’d started talking to her. “Sure,” he said, smiling back. “I’ll write it someday and never forget. I promise.”

Small talk about diaries, homework, and the occasional quiz had slowly become his moments with her. Strands of her hair still escaped her neatly tied ponytails and brushed against his notebook, but now he no longer pulled it away. Instead, it brought a strange, quiet happiness to his chest. He felt closer than ever. If the world were to stop

at that moment, he thought, he wouldn't mind being fixed there for eternity. Then came the ominous day. The school administration suddenly decided that girls had to sit in their own row. The small world Shiva had built for himself—two benches, first and second—shattered at once. But what could he do? Fate, he felt, was not something you could argue with. The girls were assigned the last row farthest from the door, right in front of the podium. Gauri chose a middle seat beside Divya. Shiva moved to the second row. And after that, seats hardly mattered anymore. By every period, he could be found on a different bench, beside a different classmate—a quiet wanderer in the small world he still called his own.

One day, nearly half the class was on its feet as Mrs. Uma stood at the front for her Sanskrit period. She was an old lady—perhaps in her sixties—her age etched clearly into her wrinkled face and frail, dry frame. Her voice, however, was as strict as discipline itself. She had a fierce devotion to her subject, arriving punctually every day and working with unwavering dedication despite her age. That morning, she was asking students to recite Sanskrit verb forms, homework she had assigned earlier, while simultaneously checking notebooks where the same forms were to be written. Shiva had done neither. His pages were blank, and so was his mind. As Mrs. Uma advanced bench by bench, his heart sank. There was no time to both memorize those merciless verbs and write them down. In panic, his eyes searched the room and fell on Gauri, sitting calmly at a distant bench. Slowly, carefully, he slipped into the seat of the adjacent row near her. “Hey, Gauri,” he whispered urgently, “can you please write my copy?” She glanced at him. “Why? Haven't you done it yourself?” “I forgot,” he admitted. “Please help me now—otherwise she'll definitely beat me with those sticks, and the scolding will be even worse.” She sighed, half-mocking yet kind. “Okay. Pass the copy.” “Thanks,” he murmured, handing the notebook over through Divya with a nervous smile. Returning to his seat, Shiva borrowed a Sanskrit book from the bench ahead and began chanting the verbs aloud under his breath, quick and desperate. Mrs. Uma moved through the class like a slow tsunami—one stick for every

wrong verb, five for an incomplete notebook. As she drew closer, his chanting grew faster, almost frantic. “Take this,” Gauri whispered suddenly, holding out his notebook. “Thanks—you just saved me at least five sticks,” he whispered back, forcing a smile, and resumed chanting as if warding off a dark spirit. At last, Mrs. Uma stopped before him. “Shiva, show me your copy and tell me the verb forms.” He handed over the notebook, stood up, and recited in the same steady chorus. She examined the pages carefully, noting the neat, elegant Devanagari script, the beautifully curved letters. “Alright, sit down,” she said at last, closing the notebook and moving on. Shiva exhaled deeply. He was saved—and Gauri had saved him.

Then came the winters, and with them the midterm examinations. At the start of the academic year, each student had been given a workbook for every subject. Those books had remained untouched, their pages blank and pristine, forgotten at the bottom of schoolbags. Now, suddenly, the administration decided they must be put to use. Every workbook had to be completely filled. It was a ridiculous idea—one workbook per subject, each packed with pages. First, one had to search for the answers, and then painstakingly write them all down. Shiva got to work immediately. He finished his Mathematics workbook in just a couple of days. He was the first in the class to do so. Word spread quickly. One by one, classmates came to him asking for help, requesting to borrow the completed book. He handed it over to the one who came first, without much thought. Then Gauri came. “I heard you’ve completed the workbook?” she asked “Yes, I did,” he replied, his voice tinged with pride. “Can you lend it to me for one day? I’ll complete mine at home today,” she said politely, her eyes filled with hope. Trouble. He had already given the book to a friend. He couldn’t ask for it back just for Gauri—what would they think of him, abandoning friends for a girl? No, he couldn’t do that. Yet he couldn’t turn Gauri away either. Their friendship, though small and new, meant the world to him. “I don’t have it right now,” he said, the words heavy with anguish. “Oh, you already gave it to someone,” she replied, disappointment evident in her voice. He couldn’t let it end like that. She couldn’t struggle over

something as simple as a workbook while he was there. “Why don’t you give your workbook to me?” he suggested. “I’ll fill it for you.” Her face lit up. “Really? You can do that for me?” she asked, smiling brightly. “Why not? I can do anything for you—” he said quickly, then corrected himself, “I mean, friends help each other, right?”

He took her workbook and completed it in a single day — finding answers, solving questions, writing everything neatly. When he returned it, he asked for her other subjects too, and she gave them to him without hesitation. He completed all of her workbooks, while his own remained blank. Only after finishing hers did he begin working on his own. Days passed—perhaps a whole week. He wrote late into the night, during free periods, even through running classes, racing against time to meet the deadline. One day, he approached her again. “Gauri, I’ve completed most of my workbooks. Only two are left—English and Social Science. I’m already writing the Social Science one. Can you please write the English workbook this Sunday? If it’s done, I’ll meet Monday’s deadline.” “I can’t, Shiva” she turned her eyes away continuing “I already have a lot of work to do at home,” she replied sharply, before hurrying back to her seat.

He stood alone in the corridor, the pale winter sunlight falling on his woollen blazer. His eyes followed her as she walked back into the classroom, settling into her bench and talking to her friends. He remained there, silent and shaken, with the submission deadline drawing dangerously close.

Off Guard

Sun was dimly lit in those winters, surrendering the sky to cold gusts and a creeping fog, everyone in class seemed to notice the heat simmering inside Shiva. His gaze lingered too long, too often, and the obviousness of his interest in Gauri was hard to miss. Rajveer occasionally teased him, calling out her name, and Shiva would brush it off with a shy, blushing smile, though his heart raced all the same. Even the smallest interactions with her, brief and fleeting, lifted his spirits for days afterward.

One day, during arts class, he had sketched a portrait of her. Carefully capturing the glasses perched on her nose, the small scar on one cheek, the neat ponytails, every detail from memory, he had shown it to Divya to pass it along to Gauri. He didn't dare hand it to her himself. When the sketch finally drifted into her hands, his gaze fixed on her face, searching for a reaction. Divya giggled as she handed it over, likely teasing Gauri. Hours of his previous night had gone into creating that sketch, and now he waited, breath held, for some sign—any sign—of appreciation. Gauri, however, cast only a brief glance at it before setting it aside, her expression neutral, unreadable. His hopes crumbled silently. Softly, he retrieved the sketchbook from Divya as

she returned it, hiding the disappointment swelling inside him.

His mind was tangled in a strange, unresolved puzzle. Had he offended her? Was it too much? He drifted through the classroom, speaking to no one, lost in his own thoughts. When recess arrived, he stepped outside, letting the warm sunlight hit his face, but even there he couldn't escape the maze in his head. Finding a quiet corner in the playground, he sat alone, trying to make sense of it all.

When recess ended, he returned to class, only to see her at her desk, head bowed low on the bench. Was she crying? His chest tightened, sinking deeper than he thought possible. He wanted to approach her, to ask what had happened, but fear rooted him in place. The room felt colder than ever, the walls closing in, shrinking him into his seat.

Soon it was time for dance class—the one period they had each week that he genuinely looked forward to. He joined his friends as the class moved to the dance hall. He knew nothing about dancing, didn't even have the courage to perform a single step, but he enjoyed the lightness of the period, the freedom it brought. He settled in a corner at the back, paying no attention to the steps, his eyes constantly searching for her, silently urging himself to go and ask what had happened.

The dance period ended, and still he hadn't seen her anywhere. Students filed back into the classroom, and he lingered near the taps, drinking water to delay returning. How could he tell her he was truly sorry? How could he promise he wouldn't draw her again? The empty corridor seemed to stretch endlessly before him. Only after a long while, when the corridor was completely deserted, did he finally turn toward the stairs and make his way back to class.

An unexpected scene unfolded as he reached the corridor outside his classroom. Several students were standing there, clustered near the door, unusually silent, all of them staring toward the entrance as if afraid to step inside. Something was clearly wrong. He moved closer and peered in through the doorway.

Ms. Sneha was in the classroom—as expected, it was the Social Science period—but she wasn't teaching. Her face was tight with anger, sharper than he had ever seen it. Gauri sat at her bench, her head

lowered onto the desk, unmoving. Ms. Sneha was addressing the class in a raised voice, her words cutting through the room, though not all of them reached clearly into the corridor.

After a moment, her gaze shifted toward the doorway, where the boys stood frozen. She signaled them to come in. One by one, they entered the classroom, slow and cautious, forming a quiet line. Shiva joined them at the back, his steps hesitant, his eyes drawn once more to Gauri's bowed head.

"It has been more than ten minutes since the class began. Do you people have any respect for time?" Ms. Sneha said, her voice sharp with anger, as she brought the stick down hard on the outstretched palm of the first student. He had already opened his hand, waiting for the inevitable. His face went pale, and his hand jerked back instantly, as if he had touched a naked electric wire.

She moved down the line without pause—two strikes for each student. The classroom was so silent that even a pencil dropping on the last bench would have echoed to the front.

So this is the day I get it too, Shiva thought, remembering how affectionate Ms. Sneha had always been toward him since the day she joined the school. His fingers, which had been tapping nervously against his thigh, slowly came to a halt. His eyes drifted away from the scene unfolding before him and fell on Gauri. She was still in the same position—head bowed, unmoving. Suddenly, the stick no longer mattered. The line shortened, one student after another stepping aside, until Shiva found himself standing right in front of her. Unexpectedly, Ms. Sneha placed the stick down on the podium beside her.

"I thought you were a good kid," she said, her voice sharp and raised. "I never imagined you would do something like this." Shiva felt something inside him collapse. Nothing made sense anymore. The entire class was staring at him—boys, girls, his friends, everyone. Yet he dared not speak a single word. He stood stiff, his legs trembling under his own weight. "There are people you think are sheep," she continued, stepping aside and turning to face the class, "but in reality, they are wolves hiding under a sheep's skin."

Shiva's eyes drifted to Gauri. She was still in the same position, unmoving, like a frozen rock—though her shoulders were drawn tight and her face stayed hidden, as if she could not bear to watch what her own words had set loose. This was the first time he was being humiliated—publicly, mercilessly. How will I face any of them now? His thoughts raced wildly as Ms. Sneha's voice kept pouring over him. "This is the age to study and build your future," she went on, now sitting on the bench kept in front of the class, "not to indulge in such petty acts of love."

Now, slowly, painfully, Shiva began to understand why he was being punished. "And just because you are good at studies," her voice echoed, "does not make you Brahma. Life is long." Sweat broke across his forehead despite the winter chill — an irony too cruel to notice. He stood frozen, unable to move or speak, his thoughts crashing over one another, drowning him completely. He could hear his own heartbeat, loud and violent inside his chest. If only the ground would open and swallow me, he thought.

Gradually, even his thoughts grew so loud that he could no longer hear her words. His vision blurred, the classroom fading, as if he himself was no longer there.

The moment stretched until the bell rang. Ms. Sneha stood up, gathered her books, and walked out. Shiva moved slowly back to his seat without looking at anyone and sat down. He did not remember how he reached home that day.

Retort

“I didn’t expect this to happen,” Suraj said, breaking the strange silence that had settled over recess. The whole group had gathered around a single bench, unusually subdued. “Did you say something to her?” Aryan asked.

Shiva, weighed down by guilt and shame, couldn’t bring himself to answer. He kept his eyes lowered, fingers tracing invisible lines on the desk.

“You helped her every time,” Rajveer said, disgust sharp in his voice as his gaze flicked briefly toward the row where the girls sat. “And this is how she returned it. I told you—girls are no one’s friends. They only think about themselves. Always selfish.”

The words continued to fly around him, but Shiva barely followed them. He was still trapped in the memory of yesterday’s humiliation. Yet, amid the bitterness and anger, the sympathy he was suddenly receiving softened something inside him. It didn’t erase the shame—but it dulled its edge, if only a little.

“It doesn’t matter,” Shiva said at last, breaking his own silence. “Let her think whatever she wants.” He paused, drawing a slow breath, as if convincing himself. “I’m doing well in studies. I can talk to people

easily. And. . .” he hesitated for a second, then added quietly, “I don’t even have an ugly face.” A strange calm settled over him as he finished, almost like relief. “If I ever wanted to,” he said, forcing a lightness into his voice, “I could talk to any girl.”

The bell rang, and everyone returned to their seats, leaving Shiva alone on the last bench with his thoughts. He sat like a statue through the next few periods, barely aware of the class unfolding in front of him. His attention drifted instead to the corridor, where the occasional passerby broke the stillness. Then his gaze settled on a pair of pigeons perched on the narrow ledge beyond the railing.

One of them would fly off now and then, returning with a twig clenched in its beak. The other waited, arranging each twig carefully into what could loosely be called a nest—a scattered, fragile pile. And every time the first pigeon returned, the other pecked at its feathers, impatient and insistent, until it flew off again. Shiva watched the quiet routine in silence, the small, relentless motions unfolding while the rest of the world seemed to move past him.

After school, he took his usual place in the van, settling into the back seat. His eyes stayed fixed on the familiar stretch of road across the highway, waiting. As the van rolled forward and bicycles passed in steady rhythm, he caught that brief patch of distance where he always saw her.

She was there—as always—with the handkerchief held to her face. But this time, she didn’t look up. Not even a passing glance. The moment slipped by quickly, swallowed by motion and noise.

He leaned back, a hollow settling inside him. His head felt strangely empty, and at times he couldn’t even tell what he was supposed to feel anymore.

He spoke to no one at home, heading straight to his room. Without changing out of his school uniform, he lay down on the bed, his eyes drifting up to the ceiling fan as it turned endlessly above him. Was he supposed to prove his feelings to her? he wondered. Did she even know what he felt—or who he was to her at all? Thoughts flooded his mind all at once, crowding one another until none of them made complete

sense. Slowly, a quieter realization settled in. Maybe giving was the only true form of love. Maybe one shouldn't expect anything in return.

Lying there, his gaze drifted toward the window, where the small razor blade rested—something he used for trimming his nails. The thought arrived suddenly, sharp and unwanted. For a moment, it scared him with its clarity.

He sat up at once, breath uneven, his heart pounding harder than before. A strange determination had flickered through him, only to dissolve just as quickly into something colder—fear, perhaps, or hesitation. He rubbed his forearms, as if trying to wipe the thought away, then pulled his woollen blazer off and folded it beside him.

Sitting there with his sleeves rolled up, he stared at his hands for a long time.

Much later, he sat still on the bed, staring at his arm as if it no longer belonged to him. The letters he had carved burned into his vision even when he closed his eyes.

He lay back again, staring at the ceiling fan as it continued to turn—steady, indifferent, unchanged. He didn't know when his eyes finally closed, or when sleep took him.

A voice woke him, calling from the other side of the door. His eyes fell instinctively to his arm. Whatever he saw there made his chest tighten. He pulled his sleeve down quickly and got up to open the door.

"You're still in your school uniform," Mami said, standing in the doorway.

"Yeah," he replied with a tired yawn. "I was exhausted. Fell asleep as soon as I got home."

"Change and freshen up. Everyone's waiting for you for dinner," she said calmly.

"Okay. I'll come."

He changed quickly, choosing a long-sleeved shirt and a jacket, then rushed to the bathroom. Whatever had happened was his alone. He couldn't let anyone see it.

Masks

It was a pleasant evening. Spring brought its own quiet colors to the world. From the outside, the village appeared still and unchanging, yet within it moved with a restlessness that never truly paused. The sun had dropped low behind the distant trees and farmland, and a deep copper light lay over everything it touched.

From the top floor, Shiva watched flocks of crows and egrets crowd the sky, circling as they prepared to settle for the night in the teak plantation nearby. Hundreds—perhaps thousands—arrived in waves, their white feathers stained red by the dying light as they landed on treetops with practiced certainty. He wondered, not for the first time, how they always found their way back. Somehow, they did. Every evening, without fail.

Lost in the sight and his thoughts, Shiva noticed the ringing of his phone resting against the railing only after it had sounded several times. He picked it up quickly.

“Hello, Mami? What happened?”

“Tea is ready,” Mami spoke. “Come down—and bring Shreya with you. She might be in the room on the second floor.” “Okay, I’m coming,” Shiva replied.

He stepped out, closing the door behind him, and crossed to the room beside the staircase. The door there was half open. He pushed it gently and stepped inside.

“Hey,” a girl sitting on the couch said, setting her phone aside on the table. “How are you?” “I’m good,” he replied, settling onto the opposite couch. “How about you? You’re Shreya, if I’m not mistaken.” “So you already know my name,” she said lightly. “It’s only been a couple of hours since I arrived.” “Mami told me,” he said. “Oh,” she smiled. “That explains it.”

He hesitated for a moment, then asked, “So... what are you doing here all alone?” “I was with Didi,” she said. “She went downstairs a few minutes ago and left me here. I didn’t really know what to do, so I picked up my phone—just waiting for someone to come.” She looked at him again. “And then you arrived.”

“Oh,” Shiva said with a soft laugh, “so I saved you.” She laughed along with him, brief and unguarded.

For a moment, neither of them spoke. Shiva sat there, watching her quietly, until he suddenly asked, his tone turning serious, “Are you a watchman?”

Shreya blinked, clearly caught off guard. “What... what does that even mean?” she asked, genuinely confused.

“You have a nice watch,” he said, pointing to her wrist, the seriousness slipping into mischief. “So I thought—you might be a watch-man.”

She stared at him for a second, then laughed. “Oh, then you’re wrong,” she said, amusement spilling into her voice. “That would make me a watch-woman. But you could be one too.” She pointed to the watch on his wrist. Shiva burst into laughter, and Shreya joined him instantly, the room filling with something light and easy.

The moment broke with another ring of Shiva’s phone. He answered it, laughter settling as he spoke. “Yes, Mami. I’m coming—just a moment.” He slipped the phone back into his pocket.

“Sadly, we’ll have to end this very important meeting,” he said, getting to his feet. “The High Court has summoned us both downstairs. Snacks are ready.”

Shreya smiled and stood up as well. Together, they walked out of the room and down the corridor, dimly lit with bulbs, the sky dark outside.

After dinner, Shiva found himself back on the top floor once again. The conversations with the guests had left him feeling unnecessary, like someone occupying space meant for others. He hadn't known any of them before, and he certainly couldn't talk freely to Shreya either—not with everyone around, watching. In some way, she seemed like him too, present yet slightly apart.

Up here, he felt calmer. From the edge of the terrace, he looked out as far as his eyes could reach, letting the distance settle him. Music hummed softly through his earphones while his attention drifted to a house across the way. Under a bright bulb, a man was making his bed on the rooftop. There were no stairs—only a narrow ladder leaning against the wall.

The man climbed down to fetch a mattress, returned, and spread it carefully, smoothing it from every side. He inspected each corner before leaving again, this time for pillows. When he came back, he placed them neatly, fluffed them, and lay down for a moment—only to sit up almost immediately, as if remembering something important. The light bulb glowed harshly above him, hanging from a bamboo stick tied to one of the columns rising from the house.

With a tired resignation, the man descended the crooked ladder once more.

Shiva watched the small sequence unfold with quiet curiosity, his gaze fixed on the rooftop across the way, as though it were a story revealing itself piece by piece. Then a sudden tap on his shoulder startled him, and he jumped at once, pulled back into the present.

He turned around to find Shreya standing just behind him. Startled, he pulled the earphones out quickly. “Yeah... hi,” he said, flustered. “What are you doing here?” His words tumbled out as if he had been pulled away from something important.

“Nothing,” she replied lightly. “I got bored downstairs, so I came up for some fresh air.” “You almost gave me a heart attack,” he said. “No,

no,” she smiled. “You have a long life ahead of you. Just not yet.”

She tilted her head, watching him. “I called you twice, but you were completely lost. Were you talking to your girlfriend?” She paused, her voice playful. “If I interrupted something important, I’m really sorry. I can go stand somewhere else—there’s plenty of space here.”

Her words were teasing, her smile full of mischief, yet there was something gentle about it too—an innocence that made the mockery feel warm rather than sharp.

“No... no,” he said quickly. “I don’t have a girlfriend.” His cheeks warmed as he spoke—barely visible in the darkness, though a few stray bulbs nearby caught the color on parts of his face. “How would a watchman even get a girlfriend?”

She raised an eyebrow, amused. “So you’ve decided to become a watchman from today onward?” He smiled back at her. “I could think about it—if that’s your command.”

“Command?” she said, a hint of mock seriousness in her voice. “How could I command you? You don’t even know me. I’m not even your friend.” The words tried to sound firm, but her smile betrayed her.

“Aren’t we already friends?” Shiva replied, mischief clear in his tone. “At least I thought we were. Am I mistaken?”

She laughed softly, finally letting go of the attempt at seriousness. “Why not? We can be friends—if you allow it.”

“Are you on Facebook?” he asked, pulling out his phone. “Yes,” she said. “I sometimes use it on my Didi’s phone. But I do have my own account.” “Okay, let me look you up,” he said, fingers moving quickly over the keypad. “Is this you?” “Yes, that’s my account,” she replied, stepping closer to see the small screen.

For a moment, the distance between them narrowed to almost nothing. He lifted his face slightly. Only a small gap separated them now. In the quiet around them, he could hear her breathing, feel the closeness in a way that made the air seem heavier.

“I’ve sent the request,” he said quietly. “Now it’s your turn to accept. I’ve done my part.”

With that, he eased himself back, breaking the closeness, and leaned

against the railing behind him. Neither of them spoke. They stood there for a long while, watching the man on the distant rooftop climb down again—this time with a torch in his hand—only to return moments later carrying a jug of water, moving about his small world as if nothing else existed.

Refraction

April's warmth had long surrendered to November's cold. Each morning, the grass lay heavy with dew, glinting like a field strewn with pearls. Shiva woke early that day. Beyond the window, the sun was just beginning to cut through the thick veil of fog, its light hesitant, diluted.

The late-night online conversations had left him drained, his eyes aching, but not enough to dull the quiet anticipation growing inside him. Today, they were leaving for a family event in Ayodhya—everyone together. And Shreya would be there.

He finished getting ready long before everyone else and spent the time waiting in the hall, moving things around, packing small items whenever someone asked. Eventually, he settled onto the couch in the porch.

His gaze lifted when he noticed a small group—three or four people—approaching from the road. He stood up instinctively, squinting for a clearer view. She was there, walking slightly behind the others. A green lehenga flowed around her, large earrings catching the light with every step, her thick hair gathered high, worn like an unspoken crown.

He stepped forward as the elders arrived, bending to touch their

feet. In between greetings and blessings, his eyes found hers for a brief moment. They exchanged a quiet smile—nothing more, nothing less—and it stayed with him.

Everything was finally ready — bags packed, children dressed, vehicles lined up outside and waiting. Shiva moved back and forth with Mama, loading the last of the items into the vehicles. Mama wasn't coming along; he would stay back at home while the others left.

"Don't take too much time," Mama said, wiping his hands on his kurta. "Leave early, or you'll struggle to find space for the rituals at the temple."

The elders boarded first, settling into their seats with practiced ease, young children lifted onto laps wherever space allowed. Shreya took one of the seats among them. As always, the teenage boys were left with the unspoken duty of adjustment. Shiva and his cousins climbed into the narrow back seats, knees pressed together, bodies folded into whatever gaps remained.

From there, he could see little of the road ahead—no fields slipping past, no changing sky—only the backs of seats and the quiet awareness that the journey had begun.

When they arrived, Shiva was met with the same familiar sight—narrow lanes packed with people, crowded markets humming with noise and movement. For a moment, it felt no different from home, as though the journey had folded back on itself.

After visiting the Hanuman Garhi temple, preparations for cooking began, as expected. Shreya joined the women, taking charge of kneading the dough, seated beside Nani. Their hands moved in quiet rhythm, voices low and steady.

Shiva, meanwhile, was handed the task of managing the children. He sat opposite the group, keeping an eye on restless limbs and wandering attention, listening from afar to the soft murmur of conversation drifting across.

He handled the role well. For some children, he had mobile games ready; for others, stories pulled from memory; and for the one persistently mischievous outlier, a single stern look that worked better than

words. He sat with two boys close to his age—Shreya’s younger brother and his own brother. The three drifted easily from one topic to another: schools, the long journey, and even the contested temple in Ayodhya, discussed with the half-formed certainty of youth.

Now and then, Shiva’s eyes wandered toward Shreya. She was shaping puris, passing them to Shiva’s mother, who stood frying them in a wide pan. The rhythm between them was effortless, practiced. Watching them, a quiet thought rose in him: Isn’t this happiness? Everything felt sorted. No urgency. No fear. Just people doing what needed to be done.

The night before, he had spoken to Shreya online, his words full of anticipation for the day ahead. Now, sitting here, the calm of the moment wrapped around him completely. Whenever Shreya smiled at something his mother said—though he couldn’t hear the words—he found himself smiling too, without needing to know why.

After the cooking was done, everyone settled down for lunch. Distributing the food fell to the boys, with Shiva quietly taking the lead. He organized them without fuss—one passing out puris, another serving sabji, one carrying water, and one handling the sweets. The system worked smoothly.

Shiva carried a plate over to Shreya, who looked a little tired now, the earlier rhythm finally catching up with her. “Did my mother make you work too much?” he asked, handing her the plate with a smile.

“No,” she replied, smiling back. “I wish I could do more for her.” She paused, then added lightly, “That depends on you, you know.”

He had no words; just a smile was his answer.

He took the two boys close to his age to the nearby temple for blessings. The crowd there was unbearable—people packed tightly on the steps, bodies pressing forward inch by inch, police guards stationed at regular intervals, watching with practiced indifference. Movement came only in slow waves, each step earned with effort.

Beside the crowded stairway ran another path, almost empty. A few people appeared through it now and then, passing easily while Shiva struggled just to keep his footing in the human tide. For a moment, he

wondered why he hadn't taken that route, and why no one else seemed to notice it.

Then his eyes fell on the board standing quietly at its entrance.

VIP Entry Only.

The answer settled in without surprise. He had heard of such things before, spoken casually, almost jokingly—but seeing the divide for the first time made it real. Two paths leading to the same place, yet not meant for the same people.

He stood there, pressed among strangers, and wondered quietly what kind of god waited inside—one who could be reached faster through influence, through money slipped unseen. If divinity was the same for all, why did access feel measured, rationed, priced?

The thought lingered even as the crowd pushed forward, slow and patient, as if everyone had already learned which path was meant for them.

The crowd pushed on, carrying Shiva and the boys with it—through the main hall, past the sanctum, and then out again—without pause or choice. There was no moment to stop, no time to look back, only the steady forward pull of bodies and breath, until they were suddenly outside, the noise thinning as quickly as it had gathered.

He returned to where the others were seated, choosing a bench just outside the hall where the cooking was still going on. The air there was quieter. He sat facing the open side, his eyes resting on the Sarayu flowing at a short distance, calm and steady.

“Hey. . .”

He turned to see Shreya standing behind him. Without looking directly at her, he brushed his hand lightly over the empty space beside him, an unspoken invitation. She sat down, and he shifted his gaze back to the river.

“Why do I always find you alone?” she said, smiling. “Rooftops, empty benches—places where no one else sits. Either you’ll become a philosopher one day, or a madman. I’m not sure which.”

“It’s nothing,” he replied calmly, turning toward her now. “I just like the peace you find away from the noise this world keeps making.”

“Oh,” she said thoughtfully. “Then I’ve brought something that might be useful for you.”

“What?” Surprise flickered across his face.

She reached into her pocket and took out a small locket. “It has Lord Shiva’s image in it,” she said. “He might help you find peace in this world. I bought it from the nearby market—I went there with Didi.”

“Oh... thank you,” he said, taking it carefully. Inside the glass pendant, Lord Shiva sat in meditation, still and distant, untouched by motion.

“I guess he’s your favorite god,” she added.

“Yes,” Shiva replied quietly. “He belongs to this world, yet he’s beyond it.” He smiled faintly. “Even my name comes from him.”

A voice called out from the hall—his mother was calling him for lunch. Shiva rose slowly and met Shreya’s eyes.

“Thank you,” he said softly. “You understand me better than anyone.” He closed his fingers around the locket. “I’ll always keep this with me.”

Then he turned toward the hall, slipping it carefully into the pocket of his jeans as he walked away.

They reached home only after night had fully settled in. Shiva, Mama, and two others close to his age began unloading the vehicles, carrying bags and bundles inside one by one. From the kitchen, the familiar sound of cups being set down announced that Mami had prepared tea for everyone.

“Why don’t you stay the night?” Nani said to Harsh, Shreya’s elder brother, who had been driving. “It’s already dark. You can leave in the morning.”

“No, no, Amma,” he replied gently, bringing his hands together in respect. “I have coaching in the morning. It will only take us about an hour to reach home from here. I missed today’s class, but if we leave now, I can still attend tomorrow’s.” His tone was polite, firm without being dismissive—decided, yet respectful.

Soon, Shreya appeared with a tray in her hands, cups of tea neatly

lined up. She moved from one elder to another, placing each cup carefully.

“You’ve forgotten one for Shiva,” Nani said, her voice laced with gentle teasing.

“I must have missed the count,” Shreya replied, a little embarrassed.

“That’s alright,” Nani continued, waving it off. “Shiva, take one from the kitchen.” Then, taking a sip of her tea, she added casually, glancing toward Harsh, “You know, Shiva makes very good tea.”

Shiva followed Shreya through the gallery. They passed the kitchen, climbed the stairs, and stepped onto the rooftop —the same porch where their friendship had quietly begun that night.

Their eyes moved instinctively toward the neighboring roof, the one that had once held the man and his careful rituals. It was empty now. Only the bulb remained, glowing faintly from the bamboo pole, swaying ever so slightly in the night air.

They stood there for a while without speaking. Their gazes met briefly, then drifted toward the distant bulb glowing in the dark. A cold breeze moved past them, unnoticed, as if it had no claim over that moment.

“You know,” Shreya said at last, breaking the silence, “I wanted to tell you something.” “Yes?” Shiva replied softly.

She took a breath. “I think... I love you.” The words came out carefully, but her heart was racing, loud enough that she was sure it would give her away. “Do you... feel the same?”

Shiva smiled, the kind that arrived before words. “I think I knew it already,” he said lightly. “A watchman can’t stay alone forever. A watch-woman is necessary, after all.”

Then, more quietly, without the joke to shield him, he added, “Of course I do.”

A call from below broke the moment Shiva wished could last forever. Shreya’s family was getting ready to leave. She hurried down the stairs, her steps quick, reluctant. Shiva remained on the rooftop, standing in the cold breeze, long after the sounds of departure faded. In the cold his sleeve dragged against his forearm, and he felt them again—the letters

he had carved there a winter ago, pale and raised now beneath the cloth, spelling a name that was not the one he had answered tonight. He drew the cuff down without looking. Some evenings he could almost forget they were there. Not this one. The moon slipped behind a veil of fog, and the night grew quieter.

Then his phone rang.

It was Shreya, calling from home.

They spoke through the night—slowly, eagerly— revisiting every glance, every word, every small moment of the day they had shared, as if saying it aloud might keep it alive just a little longer.

He returned to school, and sometimes his eyes would catch Gauri for a fleeting moment. His heart still stirred at the sight of her, a quiet ache lingering—questions rising uninvited about why she had done what she did, what she might have felt then. But those questions no longer held the same weight. They surfaced, hovered briefly, and passed.

Half of eighth standard had already slipped by. It had been nearly a year since he last spoke to her. Sometimes, he would still spot her on the far side of the highway while returning home, though even that became rarer with time. He had shifted his seat in the school van to the first row beside the driver. Krishna, the senior he once admired, had started coming on a bicycle, and Shiva had unknowingly become the most senior among those who rode the van now. The dusty back seat no longer interested him.

Without quite realizing it, he had moved forward—closer to the front, closer to himself—leaving certain questions behind, unanswered but no longer urgent.

Homecoming

The year turned over almost without his noticing, and Shiva entered ninth standard. This was the age when the school van was left behind, when the small magic of being driven gave way to something earned—a bicycle of his own. He got a geared cycle, its brakes betraying him on the very first day.

The thirty-minute ride from school to home felt like a small freedom, even as the summer's loo lashed against his face. Pedaling along the same road, beside the vast, open riverbed, he overtook the familiar school van. Watching it move past him—slow, enclosed, unchanged—he felt something settle inside him. He was no longer a boy being carried home. He was moving forward on his own.

Shreya's call had woven itself into his afternoons, a ritual as certain as the setting sun. Returning home no longer felt like an ending, but a prelude to the call—the moment he could finally hand over the day's weight down the telephone line. Most evenings were easy, a quiet exchange of ordinary things, though sometimes a sudden tension crept in between them. One such evening, Shiva sat on the terrace, watching the familiar flocks of egrets stream white across the deepening sky, the phone pressed tight to his ear.

“We’re so perfect together, you know?” Shreya’s voice came through the receiver, light and unguarded. “I showed our picture to my friends at coaching today. They all said we’re... well, they said we’re made for each other.”

Shiva felt a slow smile tug at his lips. “I think they’re right,” he murmured. “We’re like Radha and Krishna. Destined.”

There was a sharp silence on the other end. “No,” Shreya said, her voice dropping so suddenly that Shiva sat up. “I’m not your Radha.”

Something lurched in his chest. “What is it?” Shiva asked. “Did I say something wrong?”

“I don’t want to be Radha,” she said firmly, though the softness returned to her tone. “I want to be Rukmini. I want to be the one who stays, the one who is truly his.”

Shiva understood, and the tension left his shoulders. “I see,” he said. “Names are just words, Shreya. You’re everything to me. No single story could ever hold what I feel for you.”

“I know,” she whispered, and he could almost hear the smile returning to her face. “I feel the same.”

As the new academic session gathered momentum, a new rhythm took over the village. One by one, Shiva’s friends began disappearing into the local coaching centers, their cycles parked in crowded rows outside small, rented rooms. Shiva didn’t want to be the one left behind on the porch while the world moved on. He had his geared bicycle now. He pleaded with Nani for days, promising to be careful, to watch the highway, to never race. She hesitated, her worries etched into the slow way she turned her prayer beads, but eventually, his persistence won. She gave her blessing, though it came with a long list of warnings that he barely heard in his excitement.

The coaching changed the shape of his mornings. He was out of bed by six, the air still cool and smelling of damp earth. While the rest of the house was still waking, Mami would already be in the kitchen, the hiss of the stove a steady companion as she prepared a breakfast that was always too large for the hour. She moved with a quiet efficiency, ensuring he left with a full stomach, while Nani tucked packets

of biscuits into his bag—a care that refused to believe he didn't need a midday meal. By 7:30, he was on the road, pedaling toward the 8:00 AM class. It was a tight, perfect loop: an hour of coaching, then a quick dash across the town to reach the school gates by 9:30.

In the cramped coaching room, Shiva often found himself listening to explanations for things he had already mastered in the quiet of his own room. His marks in the weekly tests were consistently at the top, prompting the teacher to occasionally look up from his register and ask why he even bothered coming. Shiva would only offer a shy, practiced smile. “I just like the revision, sir,” he'd say. In truth, it was more than that—it was the proximity to the life his friends were living. Vijay sat beside him, a familiar face among the new ones, their shared silence a comfort through the long lectures.

The highway, however, held dangers that the village lanes did not. One morning, the usual blur of the roadside was broken by a cluster of people gathered near the opposite shoulder. A car lay there, its frame twisted into an unnatural shape, broken glass scattered across the asphalt. It was a sight common enough on that stretch of road to be greeted with a grim, passing glance. Shiva pedaled past, his mind already on the day's lessons, unaware of how close it had fallen. It was only later, sitting on the narrow wooden bench in the coaching center, that the reality settled in.

“A man from my village,” Vijay whispered, his face unusually pale. He had just heard the news from his uncle. “He was hit this morning. Right there on the highway.”

A cold knot tightened in Shiva's stomach. The image of the mangled car returned to him—the twisted metal, the indifferent crowd, the shattered glass on the hot asphalt. “Was he... was he hurt badly?” he asked, his voice sounding thin even to his own ears.

“I don't know much,” Vijay replied, his words barely audible over the hum of the classroom. “I was leaving for the day when the news reached us. Everything was a blur.”

The silence that followed was heavy, and the drone of the ceiling fan did nothing to lift it. Shiva looked down at his hands, resting

on the scarred wooden desk—the same hands that, only an hour ago, had gripped his bicycle handlebars with the confidence of someone who owned the road.

The lecture began shortly after, the teacher's voice a distant murmur as the class settled into notes and clock-watching. When the bell finally rang, the Tridev split apart—Shiva and Vijay heading toward the school on their cycles, while they called out to Rajveer on the phone, their voices lost in the rush of traffic.

The days settled back into their familiar rhythm, a cycle of morning air and afternoon heat. And though Shiva had not spoken a word to Gauri, nor let her name slip into his conversations with anyone else, his eyes never failed to find her. She was a quiet, fixed point in his classroom, a presence he tracked without needing to look.

But lately, her seat had been empty. One day of absence turned into two, then three, until the classroom felt strangely hollow without her. Finally, the silence grew too loud to ignore. Shiva waited until a quiet moment in the corridor before approaching Divya.

"Where is Gauri these days?" he asked, trying to keep his voice as casual as the dust on the floor. "She hasn't been in class for a while."

Divya paused, a slow, knowing smirk spreading across her face. "Oho, so you do notice her when you think we're not looking..."

"It's not like that," Shiva stammered, the tips of his ears going hot despite the cool corridor breeze. "I just... I noticed the empty bench, that's all. It's hard not to notice."

"You never asked about me when I was away, though," Divya teased, her eyes glinting with a familiar, sharp mischief.

"I do! I would!" Shiva said, his defense stumbling over itself. "You're such a nuisance, Divya. Why can't you just give me a straight answer?"

Divya dispensed with the teasing and laughed, the sound bright and effortless. "Relax, Shiva. She's just a little unwell. A change in the weather, probably. She'll be back as soon as the fever breaks."

The words were simple, yet they let the pressure of the last few days escape all at once. Shiva nodded, relief settling over him like the early evening light.

A week passed, Gauri finally appeared in class. She looked pale, her eyes tired, but she was back. Shiva felt a strange flutter in his chest, a mix of relief and something else he couldn't quite name. He wanted to say something, anything, but the words caught in his throat. He just watched her, a silent observer in the back of the room, as she settled into her seat, the familiar creak of the wooden bench a comforting sound in the quiet classroom.

He didn't know what he had expected—a grand gesture, a dramatic entrance—but the reality was far more mundane, and somehow, more significant. She was just there, a quiet presence at the back of the room, and that was enough. For now. Now and then a few girls drifted over to her bench to offer their sympathies, and she answered them with tired nods.

Ms. Sneha asked after her health and told her to come by whenever she needed help with the classes she had missed. Gauri nodded and said she would. The periods passed one after another until the lunch bell rang, and through all of them the urge to go to her and say something only tightened in his chest. He stayed on his bench, stealing glances, and let the whole break slip past without moving. It was only after the seventh period, when Gauri stepped out with one of her friends—for water, he guessed—that the moment finally forced his hand. Do or die. He waited a minute, then rose and went down the stairs and through the corridors. Near the taps he slowed. The two girls stood filling their bottles, talking; he caught the other girl's eye, and she capped her bottle and drifted toward the stairs, leaving Gauri alone. Shiva drew a breath and walked up to her.

"Are you alright? How are you feeling?"

"I'm better now," she replied.

And that was all. He stood there with nothing left to say, holding her gaze. She looked back at him, a faint smile playing at her lips. "I'll see you around," she said softly, then turned and walked away, leaving him alone by the taps, the silence of the corridor pressing in on him once again.

Lane

Winter had already settled in, and the mid-term exams had begun. The students threw themselves into work — some now taking tuitions at several places, for several subjects at once. The teachers pushed hard, reminding the class again and again that the ninth standard was a different thing altogether from the years before: if they wanted to do well in next year's board exams, the work had to start here, in the ninth itself. Shreya was in the tenth standard, and her boards fell that very year.

Shiva felt none of that pressure; he had always been good at his studies. And in any case, he had Nana at home whenever he needed help. He kept going to the coaching all the same — for the extra hours with his friends, and for the simple pleasure of being out of the house. The exams came and went, and the students finally let themselves relax. Shiva's group — the ones who went to coaching with him, along with a few others — had fallen into the habit of staying back at school a couple of hours after it let out, to play volleyball. Shiva had little skill for the game. But he loved it, and he joined them anyway, even if that mostly meant chasing down the balls that flew out of the court.

One day, playing on the court across from the school building, he

caught sight of Gauri walking along the corridor. It was the first time he had seen her in days — her attendance had grown thin and irregular of late. Curiosity got the better of him, and he turned to one of his friends to ask what she was doing here, so long after school had let out.

“What can I tell you? I saw her here yesterday as well, after school got over,” Rajveer replied.

“But why?” Shiva pushed as if someone should know.

“She’s joined a tuition here. Mr. Verma teaches Science and Maths after school. It’s good for these people—they can stay in the school hostel and don’t have to worry about space and all,” one of them replied.

Vijay got in: “Take our Robin sir, for example. He has to pay eight thousand for the room we study in.”

“And those studying there—we pay on time, but some haven’t paid the fees in four or five months. I don’t think you’ll find another teacher like him; he never even asks for them,” Rajveer continued.

“He earns plenty regardless. He takes our batch before going to his school, and after the school break he runs two more. He even owns a share in the school he teaches at,” Vijay added with a smirk.

“I didn’t know that,” Rajveer exclaimed. “He’s friends with my older cousin—he told me. You lot know nothing.”

“Are you all going to keep talking, or should we start the game?” someone called from the other side of the net.

“Yeah, start it. We’re ready,” Vijay said, quick as ever to take charge.

Shiva looked up at the second floor. It was empty. Then she stepped out of a classroom into the corridor—and she wasn’t alone. Her friend Roshini was with her. Roshini stopped at the railing, seeming to take an interest in the game on the ground below. Gauri didn’t. She tugged at Roshini’s arm, as if asking her to come away, but Roshini held her ground and pulled her back to the railing. Shiva stood rooted. Then Gauri finally glanced down, and their eyes met. For a moment the world stopped for him—until the ball struck him in the stomach. His balance went and he dropped to the ground. Everyone burst out laughing. “What happened to you? Can’t you see a ball that big?” Vijay wasn’t

pleased. But Shiva wasn't watching the game; he was watching the second floor. Then she smiled too. He broke the gaze, walked out toward the ball, threw it back in, and left the court altogether.

Vijay yelled after him, "What happened? Don't be angry, I was only joking. Come back and play from the front if you want."

"It's fine. I'm just tired," Shiva called back. "I'll join again soon. Let me get some water first."

Shiva walked to the tap near the building. There he saw Mr. Verma coming with his books, heading for the stairs. Shiva hurried over and greeted him. "Good afternoon, sir."

"Oh, hello, Shiva. What are you doing here after school?" he asked, sounding surprised.

"I was just playing volleyball with my friends," he answered.

"Well, congratulations—you got the highest marks in Maths in the mid-term exams," Mr. Verma said, pride and warmth in his voice.

"Thank you, sir. It's all because of you," he responded, head bowed.

"All right, carry on with your friends—I have a class to take," Mr. Verma said, and turned to go up the stairs.

He had climbed only a few steps when Shiva hurried after him and called out, "Sir."

"Yes?" Mr. Verma stopped and turned back. Shiva climbed the stairs up to him. "Sir, could you please teach me Science? I don't think I did well in the exams. I feel my marks will slip if things go on the way they are."

"No, no. How could you need a tuition? You've always been top of the class in nearly every subject."

"Yes, sir. But ever since ninth standard began, Science has changed completely. Now it's split into Physics, Chemistry, and Biology instead of just one subject. I think I need a little help."

"Sure, why not. Join us after class. I'm already teaching Roshini and Gauri—both Science and Maths. You could even help them with Maths while you learn Science."

"Yes, sir. I'll be ready tomorrow," he said. His face broke into a deep smile. His whole world had turned upside down.

He headed back to the match, glancing once at the second floor—empty again now—though the thought of tomorrow was already enough to lift him past the sting of the fall. “Are you better now?” Vijay asked, concern in his eyes as he walked over. “Yeah, perfect now,” Shiva replied, with such enthusiasm that Vijay smiled too.

Parallels

“How was school today?” Shreya asked.

“It was pretty good. I found out I got the highest marks in Maths,” Shiva replied, holding the phone closer, tightening his grip on the pillow he had already squeezed into a ball.

“That’s great,” Shreya said. “I wish I could do that well in Maths. I’m so worried about my boards. They say they’ll be in February, and it’s November already. I swear, if I just scrape a pass in this subject, I’ll never touch it again. I’d rather take commerce in eleventh.”

“Why do you worry so much? It’s easy once you get the core,” Shiva said, half joking.

“You don’t know it. Next year, when your boards come, I’ll ask you then. I have pre-boards next month. If I get low marks, I don’t know what Mummy will do to me.” Shreya’s voice grew audibly anxious.

“Don’t worry. It’ll be all right.”

“I don’t know how you can be so relaxed about all this. For us girls, there are two options—marry or study—and I’m not interested in the first one yet.”

“Why, what’s so wrong with that? Just imagine—you wouldn’t have to worry about earning, working outside, dealing with the world. Isn’t

that a good option?”

“You can say that because you have a choice—you’re a boy. You can’t understand what girls have to go through in this country. If you fail your exams, you’ll get married; if your family isn’t wealthy enough, you’ll get married; and if you happen to love someone, you’ll get married too—to someone else. I wish I’d been born somewhere else, not here.”

“Okay, my princess. Don’t overstress yourself. It’s just a board exam, and no one is going to marry you off to someone else. Besides, I trust you’ll do really well.” Shiva smiled and tugged the pillow tighter, as if it might disappear any moment. “But hey, tell me one thing—is there any plan of you visiting me soon?”

“I think so. I heard Bhaiya will be coming to your house next month for the Pooja. I think I’ll come along too.”

“What? There’s a pooja in my own house and I don’t even know about it,” Shiva exclaimed.

Shreya laughed. “Apparently, kids don’t get to know everything.”

“I’m not a kid. I’m just a year younger than you!” Shiva shot back.

“Yeah, coming!” Shreya called out suddenly—someone must have been calling for her.

“What happened? Who’s calling you now?” Shiva’s voice dropped, a little crestfallen.

“Boy, I’ve got some chores to do.”

“Wait—what chores at three in the afternoon?”

“I have to mop the hallway. Dadi asked me this morning, so now that I’m back from school I have to finish it before evening—after that I have to join Mummy for cooking dinner.”

“Oh god. Can’t you stay a little longer? It hasn’t even been half an hour, and you just got back from school. Get some rest,” Shiva said, and then his voice turned playful. “And some time with me.”

“No, sorry. I really have to—otherwise, if Mummy comes upstairs and sees me on a call with someone, it’ll turn into my marriage day,” she laughed.

“Okay, fine. Bye—take care. And I love you,” he said with a sigh.

“Bye-bye. Love you more.”

He set the phone aside, finally letting go of the pillow, and stretched out on the bed, looking up. The fan was still now, and it was a little cold outside. Light from the exhaust vent crept into the dark room and fell across the motionless blades, lighting up the dust that floated in the air. Shiva blew hard, and the dust scattered into a mesmerising pattern. The light felt as though it were spilling from some heaven’s door in a television serial—as if a fairy might step through it at any moment.

Late in the evening, Shiva returned from being out with his friends.

“Get ready, freshen up. Dinner’s ready,” Nani called out the moment he stepped in through the gate.

“Yes, Nani, just a few minutes.”

He came back with a bottle of hair oil and settled beside Nani while Nana ate his dinner.

“You haven’t asked for the coaching fees. It’s already the second of November,” Nana said.

“Yes, I was thinking about it. I found out that one of the teachers from my school has started teaching after hours. I asked him if I could join there instead, and he agreed. I think it’ll be much better—now I won’t have to go five kilometres out in the cold mornings.”

“How is he? You told me Robin was a good teacher, that a lot of students go to him.”

“He’s good too. In fact, he lives in the school itself—the school hired him from Bengal, and he’s really good at Mathematics and Science,” Shiva replied, slowly handing the oil bottle to Nani and settling in front of her, a little lower.

Nani quietly worked the oil into her palm and began massaging it into his head, as if she already knew just what to do.

“Fine. As long as you keep working hard, the place doesn’t matter. It’s you who has to study, not the teacher,” she added.

“Yes. Sure, Nani,” Shiva nodded.

“How much is his fee?” Nana asked.

“It’s even less than Robin sir’s. He only takes five hundred—two hundred less—and teaches two subjects instead of one.”

“Okay. But go to Robin tomorrow morning and pay last month’s fees. And when are you joining the teacher at school?”

“From tomorrow,” Shiva replied, slowly sinking down and resting his head in Nani’s lap.

“Mummy ji, shall I bring your dinner too?” Mami asked from the gallery nearby.

“Sure,” Nani said. “And Shiva, get me some water to wash this oil off my hands first.”

Shiva got up slowly. “Sure, Nani—just a minute.”

The next day, as soon as school let out, Shiva walked straight up to the second floor, his bag still on his shoulders. Roshini was standing by the railing, just outside the door of the room they were to study in.

“Hello, Roshini. How are you?” Shiva asked, all enthusiasm.

“Oh, hello. I’m great. What are you doing here?” she asked, surprised.

“Were you looking for me on the court?” he replied with a smile.

“No, no... Why would I look for you? But seriously, what are you doing here?” she asked again.

“Just checking whether you’re doing your best in your studies,” he said, his tone turning teasing.

“Don’t tell me you’ve joined the tuition with us?” Her mouth fell open.

“Sure did,” he said, lowering his head with a smile. “Now that Mr. Verma himself is teaching, how can I not attend?”

He peeked through the open door into the room.

“She’s inside. Just having her lunch,” Roshini added, teasing.

“No... no... I wasn’t looking for her. I was only checking if sir had arrived.”

“Do you think I’d be standing out here if sir were already in?”

“That’s true too. Shall we go in?” he asked.

They both walked in. The front seat was turned around to face the rest—Mr. Verma’s, most likely—and in the seat before it sat Gauri,

her lunchbox open.

Shiva crossed to her, threw his arms open in a film-hero flourish, and grinned. “Hi—I’m Shiva. You must have heard the name.” He held out his hand for a handshake.

Everything went still. No one moved, and Shiva stood there frozen, hand out, waiting. Then, after a moment, Gauri simply lifted her own hand, fingers glistening mid-bite, to show she was eating.

“Oh. Right. My bad.” He pulled the hand back and, to save face, shook it firmly with his own.

Roshini burst out laughing. “Too bad you’re not Rahul—the one Shahrukh plays. That entrance only works in the movies.”

Search

“Nani, can you please give me eleven rupees? I need to recharge my phone,” Shiva asked, sitting in the verandah.

“Didn’t Nana get it recharged just last week?” Nani replied, carrying on with the knitting she had probably been at for the past month.

“Yes, but I wanted an internet recharge. It’s separate from the calling one—it’s for searching things on the internet,” he said, sliding closer to her on the sofa.

“What is internet?” she asked innocently, her eyes still on the needles.

“It’s like a whole world inside the phone that holds all the information about everything there is. You write down your questions and it answers them.”

“Oh god, the things people have made.” She stopped knitting and turned to him. “Can it tell me where my earrings are? I kept them in one of the boxes and now I can’t find them.”

“No, Nani,” Shiva replied with a sigh, “it only knows what people have put on it for others to see.”

“Ohh.” Her enthusiasm drained away, and she went back to her knitting. “Then what’s the use? You could just ask the person who

put it there in the first place.”

“But how would I know who knows the answer?” Shiva said, confident, as if the argument alone could win it for him.

“Shhoo... shooo...” Nani called out sharply at a cat trying to slip inside with its kitten. Shiva got up and moved quickly toward the gate; at the sight of him, the cat darted out.

“All right—go to the almirah and take it from there,” Nani said, returning to her knitting.

“Sure. I know where it is.”

“And once you get your internet,” she added with a smile, “show it to me too—what it looks like.”

Shiva hurried to the nearby shop, bought a recharge coupon, and came back home, his steps quick—as though something were slipping away and he had to reach it before it was gone. He came in through the gate, Nani still sitting where he’d left her, and rushed straight past her.

“Where are you going? Did you get it?” she asked.

Shiva stopped just behind her. “Yes. I’m going upstairs—the network stays weak down in the house.”

“But it’ll be cold up there, look how breezy it is,” Nani said, concern in her voice. “You’ll fall sick. Why not go up some other day, when there’s a bit of sun?”

“No, it’s fine, Nani. I’ll stay in behind the bulkhead.”

“Still—wear your jacket on top,” she added.

It was truly windy, just as Nani had said. Down on the street the wind was weak, broken up by the houses all around, but three floors up it had nothing to stop it. Not that anything could have stopped Shiva. He scratched the voucher and got the 20 MB of data he’d been so impatient for, opened GPRS, went to Facebook, and made himself a profile—just his name on it. A profile picture? Forget it; the phone couldn’t even render the Facebook logo.

He opened the search bar and typed “Gauri Mishra.” A long list of girls came up, not one of them with a picture. Now that was a problem—how was he to know which one was really her? He read

through every bio; none carried any mark of his school, or even his town. He was stuck. Then a thought struck him, and he began sending “Hi” to all of them, one after another—two hours of patience in the cold, until his phone finally died.

“You know, I tried to reach you so many times all evening, but your phone was off. What were you even doing? You know how little time I get to talk to you,” Shreya said, her voice sharp with anger.

“I’m sorry. The phone just died—I put it to charge and forgot to switch it back on. I didn’t mean to hurt you,” he said, defending himself.

“It’s not about that. How can you forget that I call you in the evening?” she asked, her voice rising.

“I’m really sorry—but please, keep your voice down. It’s one in the morning; someone could wake up and hear you,” he said, worried.

“I know. That’s why I’m on the roof. No one can hear me up here.”

“What? Why are you on the roof at this hour? It’s freezing outside. Please come down—we can talk tomorrow,” he said, his voice growing more concerned.

“It’s fine. Bother me as much as you like while you still have me. Because if I’m ever gone, you won’t find anyone who loves you the way I do.” Her voice grew sadder, close to tears.

“Hey—why are you crying? I’m right here. I’m not going anywhere. Don’t worry.”

“I’m not crying, it’s just my nose running,” she said, clearly wiping her tears and trying to stop sobbing.

“Please, don’t hide from me. I know you. I’m really sorry—I didn’t mean to hurt you. Please forgive me,” he said, as gently as he could.

“It’s okay. Just remember to answer when I call. I really don’t get much time with you.”

“Understood, ma’am. You command my life,” he said, joking.

“Now please, come down and get some sleep. You’ll miss school tomorrow,” he went on.

“No, I won’t. Someone will wake me in the morning.”

“Oh—I forgot, my princess has her servants too.” They both cracked up.

“So—have you confirmed you’re coming for the pooja? It’s less than a month away now,” he asked.

“Yes, sir, I will. And I’m going shopping this weekend—tell me your favourite colour and I’ll buy something for myself in it.”

“It’s black. But I don’t think it would suit you. Take something in crimson—it would look best on you.”

“Sure, I’ll see,” she replied, with a final wipe of her tears. “Okay, I have to go now, or I’ll get dark circles—and I’m telling you, I don’t look good with those,” she added, smiling.

“Sure, sure...” Shiva said, and they both laughed before hanging up.

“Wake up. Shiva, wake up. We have to leave early.”

Shiva opened his eyes to find Mama standing beside his bed. Rubbing them, he asked, “What happened?”

“Let’s get the water pump out to the field. I’ve found someone to help me through the day, and you can leave for school once we’ve set it up,” Mama said, taking a sip of tea from his cup.

Shiva turned to his phone and checked the time. “But it’s five in the morning.”

“Yes—Shirilal will be here by five thirty. I’ve already carried the pump set out to the gate. Get ready.”

“Okay.” Shiva pulled himself out of the warm bed into the cold and headed for the bathroom.

He came back to the verandah a few minutes later.

“Babu, I’ve left the tea on the table with some snacks—eat before you go,” Mami said, heading back inside through the gallery.

Shiva picked up the tray and went out to the porch, where Mama stood holding his cup of tea, inspecting the pump set.

“Isn’t Shirilal the one who joined the police? A constable?” Shiva asked, taking his first sip from the cup. “Rohan said he sat the medical exam and had cleared every stage before it.”

“He did,” Mama said, setting his empty cup aside and crouching by the machine to inspect something only he understood. “But his family couldn’t put together the ten lakhs the recruiters wanted. So he had to turn back.”

“But he’s good at his studies, and his fitness too—I heard he’s one of the fastest runners of everyone who trains at the Tedhiya orchard.” Shiva picked a pakora off the tray.

“Talent isn’t the whole of it, Shiva.” Mama said with a sigh, already fixing something with a wrench.

“Namaste, uncle,” a voice called from across the street. Shiva looked round to see Shirilal coming toward them.

“Have some tea, Shirilal, and then we’ll go,” Mama said without turning.

“No, uncle, it’s fine. I had breakfast at home—my mother made it for me,” he replied, his voice bright, not a trace of the loss he’d been through.

“Shiva, finish up quickly,” Mama said, wiping the oil off the part he’d just fixed.

Soon Shiva and Shirilal took up the pump set, Mama wheeled the bicycle with the pipes loaded on it, and they set off for the field. Dawn was breaking on the horizon, a reddish hue glazing the riverbed and the mustard field. Across the river, the far village seemed dim beyond the dazzle of the water, the people moving about it small as stick figures—almost cartoonish as they crossed the fields.

“Shirilal, Shiva and I will get the pump set up. You take the bucket and fetch water for the suction,” Mama said, and began untying the pipes. Shiva joined in, dragging the pump toward the bore.

“But Mama—what will he do now? He can’t just go on doing manual labour after finishing his graduation,” Shiva asked, his eyes full of concern.

“He’s still looking for other government jobs.”

“And if the same thing happens again?”

“Can we stop trying just for fear of failing?” Mama said, fitting the pipe to the pump and the bore. “What if we fail? We keep searching

for what we want. Who knows what God has kept hidden for us.”

Shiva nodded, watching Shirilal come toward them along the narrow farm trails, a bucket in each hand.

Convergence

The morning bicycle ride felt like riding into an abyss that began ten feet ahead. Fog spread all around, and the wind was the worst of it. The road along the dry riverbed, which had once carried the summer loo, now lay hidden under a white veil. Shiva usually reached school half an hour early, as did most of his friends. Sitting beside a fire before the morning assembly had become their routine. The hostel students joined them too, sometimes, once they had bathed in the chilling water.

“Why didn’t you come for the volleyball games yesterday?” Vijay asked, slowly pushing a piece of broken bench-wood into the fire. “No, it’s just that I’ve joined tuition with Mr. Verma after school,” Shiva replied, his eyes on the flames as they gently grew. “Oh—so that’s why you weren’t at Robin sir’s coaching today. But wasn’t Robin sir teaching you well enough already? He liked you so much, too.” “I know. I told him yesterday, when I was there, that I was leaving,” Shiva said, stretching his hand forward to push another log into the fire. As he did, the sleeve of his blazer slipped back and his arm caught the light. The letters had faded almost entirely now; only a darker circle remained. He pulled the sleeve down quickly. “I know why you joined there,” Rajveer said with a mischievous grin. “Just take care of it cleanly this time.

Make sure it doesn't end up like the last."

"Don't worry," Shiva said with a smile. A bell rang out, echoing across the campus, and they stood up for the assembly. Gauri led the prayer every morning; she was the school's lead singer. After all the gaps, his mornings had once again begun with her voice.

Shiva stayed back in class until everyone had left. Only once it was empty did he pick up his bag and walk up to the second floor. His friends were still on the ground below, playing. He glanced at them as he crossed the corridor, and Rajveer, happening to look up just then, caught his eye and gave him a thumbs up. Shiva smiled and walked on. Entering the room, he found a closed tiffin on the desk, Roshini and Gauri seated on either side of it, both staring at him. He paused. "What happened?" he asked. "She won't let me eat," Gauri said, drama in her voice. "It's just that she's made gajar-halwa for the first time. I wanted you to taste it too, not only me. Suppose it's bad—really bad, salt-instead-of-sugar bad. How can I tease her about it all on my own? I need a backup, right?" Roshini said, determined. "Can I join, then?" Shiva asked Gauri, pointing to the tiffin. "Sure. But if you two overdo it, remember—I'll make halwa out of you as well," Gauri replied.

Shiva took the spoon resting on top of the tiffin, and Roshini opened it. He scooped out a little and put it in his mouth. His face went pale and still; he even stopped chewing. The girls' heartbeats stopped with him. "Is there really salt in it?" Roshini exclaimed. Shiva nodded. Roshini took the spoon and tried a taste of her own. She froze too. Now the pressure fell on Gauri. "What? No..." she shot back. "I tasted it this morning—it wasn't this bad. What's wrong?"

Shiva and Roshini broke into laughter, and it pulled Gauri into a smile too. "No, it's genuinely good. I wish you'd bring it more often," Shiva said, calming her. "Oh, thanks. Let's see how many more days we have carrots at home," she said, smiling along with them.

They finished the box just before Mr. Verma arrived, then took the seats facing him—Gauri on the left, Roshini in the middle, and Shiva on the right.

Days passed slowly. Mr. Verma arrived for tuition about half an

hour after school let out, and the three of them made the most of that gap—sharing food, usually Gauri's tiffin, then heading down to the ground for a game of badminton, or letting Shiva teach them how to handle a volleyball. His friends had slowly dropped the habit of playing after school as the winter turned harsher, so the court lay open now for the three of them, for the few minutes they had.

One such winter evening, Shiva returned home from school. Nani sat near the small fire, which had almost faded. He stood his cycle in the backyard veranda, and after changing his clothes he came back and settled down beside her. "The fire's almost gone. Should I add some wood?" he asked. "Yes. But you'll have to split the log first—it's too large," Nani replied, slowly turning over the remaining embers with a small stick. Shiva stood up, fetched a smaller log and a hand axe, and started splitting it.

"Mama has brought everything for tomorrow's pooja. Before it gets dark, go to Pandit ji's house and remind him about tomorrow," Nani said. "Will Pandit mama come, or his son?" Shiva asked, gathering the smaller pieces he'd split and setting them to one side. "His son will come. He's grown old now, and much weaker. And he's been unwell with the cold," Nani replied. "Okay, then I'll just call him—I have his number in my phone," Shiva said promptly. "No, go to him in person. And meet his father too; ask after his health. He used to come to our home so often," Nani replied, turning the embers again. "When you were little, he'd play with you for hours. You were always asking him to play horse-horse, and he would carry you on his back," Nani continued. "But his health has gotten the better of him now. Otherwise he was always so active—from his priestly duties to the fields." "All right, Nani. I'll go to his house," Shiva said, gathering a few more pieces and laying them in the dying fire.

Soon the fire brightened. Shiva stood up and set off for Pandit ji's house. He reached it before long and found the veranda empty. He called his friend Vinay, Pandit ji's son, and asked him to come out. Vinay came around from the next street, and they shook hands. "What happened, Shiva?" Vinay asked. "Oh—I came to remind you

about tomorrow's pooja," he replied. "Yes, don't worry, I remember. I'll come in good time," Vinay said with a smile. "You could have just called me," Vinay added. "No, I also wanted to see your father—I heard he's unwell," Shiva said. "Yeah, his knee's swollen from the cold," Vinay replied. "He had an operation on it once, and now it aches whenever the weather turns. And this time he's caught a cold as well." "Oh. Have you taken him to a doctor?" Shiva asked. "Yes. The doctor's given medicines. But mostly it's about looking after him."

"Where is he?" Shiva asked.

Vinay led the way inside, and they crossed the veranda into a gallery. It was dark, with almost no light except what came in from either end, and it opened onto an inner courtyard that lay open to the sky. They turned left, and Vinay slid a door open. The room was lit by a single bulb, hanging from a holder tied to a nail on the wall. Pandit ji lay on the bed under a blanket, his wife seated beside him with a polythene bag of medicines in her lap. "Namaste, Mami," Shiva said, joining his hands. "Be happy, son," she replied. "How are you? It's been so long since I saw you," she added, setting the polythene bag aside near the pillow. "I'm good, Mami. How are you? And how is Mama?" he asked. "He's better now. I was just giving him his medicines—the ones before dinner," she said, her voice growing heavy, almost breaking into tears. "Look who's come," she said, gently tapping the blanket. A face slowly emerged from beneath it, rising against the headrest of the bed. "Oh—Shiva? How are you?" he asked, joy in his voice. "I'm good, Mama." Vinay pulled a chair over from the side and sat down. "How are your Nani and Nana?" Pandit ji asked. "They're well too." "I hope Rama ji makes you well again soon—so I don't have to rely on Vinay for the pooja," Shiva said, trying to lift the mood. Vinay smiled, and so did Mami. "Definitely. But for now, you'll have to make do with just him," Pandit ji said, breaking into a light laugh. "What other choice do I have?" Shiva added, with a glance toward Vinay.

Discord

Shiva brought a mango-tree log to the front porch, along with the small axe. He set about chopping it into smaller pieces, calling for Rahul as he worked. “Rahul...”

Rahul came out onto the porch. “Yes, bhaiya?” he answered.

“Go and get some fresh mango leaves for the pooja,” Shiva said.

“I was about to wash the fruits for the prasad,” Rahul replied.

“Fine. Leave the fruits in water and bring the leaves first.”

“Okay,” Rahul said, and went back inside.

The log was hard to break. A knot in it made the work stubborn; only small pieces occasionally split away, while most of his blows simply recoiled. The cold did him no favours either, and sitting on the freezing porch made it worse still—the numbness in his hands made each strike harder to bear. He kept at it anyway, as if he had turned it into a contest between himself and the log.

He had grown so absorbed in it that he didn’t notice someone laughing at him. He looked up to find Shreya standing there, while Harsh, her elder brother, walked into the veranda. Her mocking smile embarrassed him somehow, though the happiness of her arrival won out. Her hair was done up in such a charming way, matching the colour of her

suit, which was laced with golden edges; and the smile on top of it was more than he could bear—harder than the axe’s recoil.

He stayed quiet a while, as if time had stopped, before he was jolted back by Harsh.

“Is it too knotted?”

“Yes, it is,” he replied, as Shreya moved on toward the veranda.

Shiva stood up and was about to call out, but Rahul appeared first.

“Rahul, bring water and something sweet, and ask Mami to prepare tea,” he said.

“But I was just leaving for the mango leaves you asked for,” Rahul said, a little frustrated by the ever-changing demands.

“It’s okay—let him go for the leaves. I’ll manage the rest here. I haven’t come as a guest, to enjoy myself and leave,” Shreya said.

Harsh, meanwhile, noticed Nani, who had just come out into the veranda, and went over to her.

“Sure, why not? May I have a cup of tea too, please?” Shiva asked with mischief, still unable to pull his eyes away from her.

After a while, Harsh came out to the porch, where Shiva was still wrestling with the log.

“It won’t break like this,” he said.

Shiva turned and asked, “What should I do, then?”

“Bring a chisel and hammer—they’ll do the job cleanly.”

“Wait.” Shiva dropped the axe and came back with them.

Harsh sat down, held the chisel in one hand and the hammer in the other, and with just a couple of strikes it sank into the wood. The next went in a little farther along, and cracks began to show.

“Thanks—I’ll do the rest,” Shiva said, stepping in.

“Sure.” Harsh handed him the hammer and walked back to the veranda, to Nani. The two fell into conversation.

Soon Shreya came over with a tray, a cup of tea on it. “Tell me if it’s good,” she said, drawing his attention.

“Does it matter? If you’ve made it for me, it’ll always be good,” he said with a smile.

She stepped closer and leaned in, bringing the tray within his reach, and he lifted the cup. He took a sip and gestured to show how good it was.

Meanwhile, Shreya gathered up the split wood and carried it into the veranda, near Nani.

“That’s enough, Shiva. Put the rest inside,” Nani called to him.

After putting everything back, he returned to the veranda, to Nani. Rahul had already brought the fruits over, all washed, and Shiva, along with Rahul and Harsh, began cutting them into pieces. Shreya joined Nani and went inside to prepare the other items.

“Shiva, when is Vinay coming?” Nana asked, setting his newspaper aside.

Shiva glanced up at the wall clock. “He should be here any moment now. I told him we’d leave for the temple by nine, and it’s already eight-thirty,” he replied.

Mama came in with a set of carpets, bundled and tied neatly together.

Soon enough, Vinay arrived with his bag of manuscripts. He shook hands with Shiva and greeted Nana and Mama before sitting down beside Mama on the sofa.

“How is bhaiya now?” Mama asked.

“He’s better now than before. The medication’s ongoing. I’m taking him to the doctor for another scheduled visit,” Vinay replied.

In no time, Shreya brought each item out to the veranda, one by one, as Nani prepared them inside. With a practised ease, Nana took the lead, the boys carrying the items behind him. Rahul followed on a bicycle with the carpets. Mama brought out his motorcycle for Nani, and Shreya rode with her brother in the car, which carried the heavier buckets of prasad.

Reaching the temple, they found the barber’s wife, Guni, who had already cleaned the place. They began arranging the items—Mama and Harsh spread the carpets, and Vinay prepared the altar, while Shreya and Nani sat on the chabutara under the huge neem tree. Slowly, people began to arrive. The men sat a little apart, some under the

tree, some on chairs pulled from a nearby hut. The women sat closer, on the carpets. It was an open temple, with almost no structure to it—just a statue and a pedestal. The Harijan women from the nearby houses arrived and sat to the right, a little apart from the other women. The children gathered at the edges, caught up in their own games.

Nani and Nana sat in front of the altar, and Vinay began his chants. Shreya sat beside them, helping out with whatever item was needed next for the ritual. Shiva went back to the other men near the hut, a few feet away, who were discussing what bad shape the temple was in and how the villagers ought to collect funds to renovate it. Everyone had their own idea—one wanted marble on the walls, another loud-speakers—each pressing the advantages of their own suggestion against what was actually needed, pausing now and then to fold their hands and hail the goddess whenever Vinay blew the conch.

At the end, Vinay blew the fifth conch, announcing the close of the ritual. Shiva called Rahul in and took up the next task—distributing the prasad. He took the bucket of flour prasad, and Rahul took the fruits. Once Rahul had started, Shiva picked up his bucket and began from the end opposite Rahul's. He handed a paper bowl to the first woman in the line and began scooping out the flour with a metal bowl to drop into the one he'd given her. He glanced up to find she hadn't held it up to receive the prasad; he fumbled a little and asked her to hold it out straight, which she did. He put in the flour, then realised the bowl he'd given her was one of the smaller ones, meant for the fruits. He went back to fetch the larger ones, and overheard one woman grumbling to another—"What has he done? How can we take this prasad now? Doesn't he have the sense to start from this side?"—as she slipped into her mouth the piece of apple Rahul had given her.

Now Shiva found himself in a dilemma. Should he go back to the women waiting for their larger bowls, or do what was expected of him? He picked up the bundle of larger bowls and the bucket and went back to the same woman, who was still holding the small one. He walked slowly along the whole line, giving out the prasad one by one, smiling as the older women offered him their blessings. At last, having finished

with that group, he turned back to start on the next.

The front group of women—the ones who had been fussing earlier—were looking at him, and then at Nani, with an expression he couldn't read.

Then Nani stepped in. "Take that bucket of flour near the goddess's pedestal—it has enough in it, or else you'll have to come back midway through the distribution," she said, pointing, then smiled at him.

Shiva did as she said, and went on distributing the prasad and receiving the blessings.

By afternoon, they were all back home. Shiva headed to his room, while the elders stayed in the veranda talking and Shreya went inside to Mami. He lay on his bed, facing the wall, his eyes settling on the picture of Lord Rama that hung on it—seated beside an old woman, eating the berries from her hand, his brother at his side.

His peace broke at a knock on his open door. His gaze shifted to it: Shreya stood there with two plates in her hands.

"May I come in?" she asked, a tease in her voice.

Shiva sat up on the bed. "Why not? It's already open for you," he said with a smile.

She sat down beside him, setting the food on the bed. "You didn't come with the others for lunch, so I brought it here myself."

"Thanks. It's better to eat in your company, I guess," he said.

"My friends say my company's the best," she replied, a touch of attitude in her voice.

"Sure, sure," he said, laughing. She made up the first bite and held it in front of his mouth. He paused. She gestured with her eyes for him to open it, and Shiva went along and took it. Then he waited for her to make up the next.

She looked up at him. "That was it—now use your own hand."

"I'm not going to touch it at all now. You started this, so you'll have to finish it," he said.

Ingratitude

Evening began to set in. Shiva moved up to the roof, joined by Shreya. The dim sun that had risen through the day was already giving way to the inevitable fog. The nearby orchard, once packed with cranes, was empty now. The season must have driven the birds from their homes—though they always returned. Shiva laid a mat on the cold floor, and the two of them sat together, watching the sun sink slowly below the horizon.

“Isn’t it colder here?” Shiva asked.

“I’m not going to your room—what if someone notices us? And it’s a nicer spot anyway, so calm,” Shreya replied, a little frustration in her voice.

“Okay, okay... but why sit here, by the bulkhead?” Shiva asked, expecting a reason.

“Remember this wall? We stood right here last year, watching that man,” she said, smiling. Then her tone shifted abruptly. “I miss you so much, being so far from you.”

“Hey...” Shiva lifted her lowered head. “Why do you worry so much? One day we’ll be together for good,” he continued.

“I don’t want to leave. I just want this moment to freeze for us. I

could never go down those stairs,” she said, her voice deepening.

“But then Harsh bhaiya will have to skip his morning class,” he said with a smile, and she broke into a mix of laughter and tears.

“One day I’ll give you everything, and then we won’t have to hide. In fact, I’ve already planned a few places for us to visit together,” he said.

“Which places? But no heights, please—I’m afraid of falling,” she said, slowly wiping her tears.

“What about Manali? I’ve heard it’s a really nice place, with lots of snow,” he said.

“But isn’t it on a mountain?” she pressed.

“Oh, yes. And now that you’ve put mountains on your enemy list, I don’t want to visit them ever either. Besides, what do they even have? Just some rocks with solid water,” he answered.

“I like the sea,” she replied.

“Ohh... like in Goa? But people drink there, you know,” he said, teasing.

“I don’t like people who drink. Then we’ll go to a forest somewhere,” she said.

“Who asks to go to a forest? You really are unique,” Shiva laughed.

“It doesn’t matter where we go, as long as I’m with you,” she said, moving closer and hugging him, laying her head on his chest as if hiding.

“Hey...” Shiva turned his head down to look at her. He moved aside the strands of hair fallen across her face and gently kissed her forehead. Shreya sat up, out of his embrace. Shiva’s eyes locked with hers, and for a moment Shreya got what she wanted—time froze. Shiva moved closer to her. He could feel the warmth of her breath now, despite the cold breeze moving all around them. She leaned in and kissed him. Time didn’t just freeze—it disappeared, for them both. Shiva wrapped his arms around her as she sank closer. Moments later she moved lower and rested her head back against his chest.

His eyes fell on his arm wrapped around her—the dark mark, faded though it was, unsettled him still.

Ebb

The sun shone dimly, giving out its warmth; the afternoon was pleasant. Shiva headed out of class after everyone else had left. Hitching his bag onto his right shoulder, he walked along the second-floor corridor and straight out to the playground. Sitting at the edge of the ground, where the grass grew a little taller, he noticed the volleyball court, its net taken down. The makeshift bamboo poles they'd used for the net stood bare, almost meaningless now. Grass had begun to grow back over the soil that the players' feet had once trodden bare.

Looking up, his gaze fell on Mr. Verma, hurrying along the lane past the ground to reach the class. Shiva got up and jogged over to him.

"Hey, Shiva, how are you?" Mr. Verma asked.

"I'm good, sir," he replied, slowing to match Mr. Verma's pace. "So, it's maths today, then?" Shiva added, glancing at the RD Sharma book in Mr. Verma's hand.

"Yeah. I've picked some questions from the Triangles chapter for practice today," Mr. Verma replied as they carried on toward the stairs.

"Yeah, I tried some of the questions from this chapter," Shiva replied without much enthusiasm.

“Great—so you’ve already started it!” Mr. Verma exclaimed.

“Sort of,” Shiva replied.

“How do you always start so early, in every chapter?” Mr. Verma asked.

“My Nana is a retired maths lecturer. So since the beginning, we’ve solved problems together—even ones that don’t matter for exams,” Shiva replied.

“Oh, that explains it. There’s a reason I call you the Master Blaster of Maths,” Mr. Verma laughed.

They went up the stairs and along the corridor, and reached the class. Mr. Verma set his book down in its usual spot. Shiva looked over to find the girls had swapped their seats. He pulled another bench over from the side and sat down, keeping his bag to his left.

“So, in today’s class we discussed triangles. I’ve chosen some questions for practice,” Mr. Verma said, and began drawing a diagram on the board, the heavy book still in his other hand.

Shiva opened his book and began solving the question, finishing before Mr. Verma had even written it on the board. Then he sat fully engrossed, watching how Mr. Verma went about solving it.

After a few questions, Gauri set her book to her left and slid a little to the right.

“Okay, so that’s all for today. Please try to solve the remaining ones I asked you to mark. These will be really important for the exams,” Mr. Verma said, closing his book and rubbing his hands together to get the chalk dust off them.

“Sir, will you give us a party for the coming New Year?” Gauri asked.

“Yes, sir. Students from other coaching classes I’ve met are having one too. Can we please have one as well?” Roshini joined in, sounding almost pleading, yet warm.

“What sort of party? It’ll be really cold by then—look how cold it is already,” Mr. Verma replied.

“We can just bring a cake and cut it together,” Roshini replied.

“But I won’t be here then. The vacation starts before that, and I’ll probably be back by the 5th of January,” Mr. Verma said.

“It’s fine. We can do it on the 5th, then,” Gauri said.

“Shiva, what do you think? Can we have it?” Mr. Verma asked, turning to him.

“Shiva, I’ll break your nose if you say no,” Roshini called out with a laugh.

Shiva raised his eyebrows. “What choice do I have?” he said, ending in a smile. “But when do the vacations start?” he asked.

“From the 25th,” Gauri said, turning to him. He nodded.

“And I have to catch the train tomorrow, after school. So technically, this is our last class of the year,” Mr. Verma added with a satisfied smile.

“So, just three days of school left,” Gauri pointed out.

“Does it matter? The vacation—if you can even call it that—is only ten days,” Roshini replied.

“Then the DM’s orders will keep coming for holidays anyway, as the weather keeps dipping and rising,” Shiva replied, zipping up his bag.

“Sorry, everyone, I have to go—my wife’s calling. I promised I’d do the packing while talking it over with her, as if I were a child,” Mr. Verma laughed, bringing the phone to his ear.

Gauri and Roshini blushed at that. Shiva stood up and walked out behind Mr. Verma, his bag back on his right shoulder.

He walked with Mr. Verma to his bicycle near the stand. Unlocking it, he started walking it back toward the central lane that led to the exit gate. The rule against riding your bicycle on the premises had always felt bogus to him, especially when the place was this empty.

Continuing ahead, he saw Gauri and Roshini standing at the crossing, talking. He moved past them, off to one side, without joining their conversation.

“Oh, Mrs. Slim Fit—where are you off to?” he heard Roshini call from behind.

He paused and turned back to see the girls closing in. “You’re such a bad girl,” he threw at Roshini.

“By god, that slim waist, cinched in by that tight belt—if you were a girl, I’d have proposed to you right here on the road,” Roshini broke into laughter.

“What the hell? What rubbish comes into your mind,” Shiva laughed, almost embarrassed.

“Let me show you,” Roshini said, looking around. “There’s a good flower,” she added, and moved off to get one.

“Is she even a girl, or what?” Shiva said, turning to Gauri.

“Ask her yourself,” Gauri laughed, covering her face with her handkerchief. “But first, tell me, where were you? I was waiting for you before the tuition. I’d brought aloo-paratha today—it took me an hour to make,” she added, her laugh fading into sternness.

“I was busy somewhere,” he replied flatly.

“Oh, what the hell. It hasn’t even been a moment, and you’ve already betrayed me for someone else,” Roshini said, returning with a marigold in her hand, her furious face hiding the laughter beneath—making Gauri blush.

Shiva laughed, taking the flower from Roshini. “Thanks, ma’am. I’ll keep it close,” he replied mockingly, as they reached the gate. Beyond it, he swung onto his bicycle and sped off toward the main road, and was gone.

The vacation was closing in fast—just a day left before it. A few teachers, the ones from far away, had already left. The class after lunch was left free, its teacher one of those who had gone, and Eric sir was assigned to take it. He was an artist himself; he didn’t know much Hindi, but he was very playful with the students, even in his fifties. His large belly, straining to rip out of his white shirt, the dark skin peeking through, made for a comical sight. The students loved him for his fun-loving nature. He taught English, mostly to the middle classes.

The class was chattering away, busy gossiping ahead of the coming vacation. Noise was the only possible outcome.

“Keep quiet, class. Open your books and read,” Eric sir yelled.

“Sir, can you please teach us something?” one boy yelled before ducking back into the crowd.

“No... do your own work. You must have homework,” Eric sir replied, visibly searching for the offender.

“Garima, stop talking, please,” Eric sir said. His threats were as polite as his belly.

“Sir, she’s talking to me. I’m not talking,” Garima replied, pointing to her benchmate.

“Sir, please teach us the essay on Saint Valentine from the book,” another offender raised his voice.

“I’ve already narrated it many times—no more,” he replied, still unable to find who’d spoken.

“Sir, then the essay on the train, please,” one more voice echoed in the already noisy room.

“Leave the train and focus on your own engines,” sir replied. His pronunciation of the words drew the attention of many, who laughed in unison.

Eric sir’s gaze fell again on Garima, who was talking to the other girls.

“Why do you keep talking, dear?” his question aimed at her.

“Sir, it’s not me—they keep talking and pulling me in,” Garima replied, laughter trickling across her face.

“Darling Garima, oil your own engine—don’t look at others’,” Eric sir said.

The boys broke into laughter, all eyes turning to her. Garima went pale, as if the sky had fallen on her. She tried to move away from her group, sliding along the bench.

“Sir, she doesn’t focus on her own engine—she’s only interested in others’,” a voice came from the crowd, fuelling the laughter among the boys.

“Are you dumb, or what?” a voice rose above the surrounding noise. Everyone’s gaze shifted to Shiva, now on his feet. “What the hell are you doing? Do you even have any sense?” he yelled, so loud it could have been heard from the next classroom. The class fell silent, as if they’d seen a ghost.

He flung his book shut, and it skidded to the ground, before he

rushed out of the class. He returned a minute later with Vivek sir, the teacher coordinator.

“Sir, please come with me,” Vivek sir said to Eric sir as he entered the class. “And the rest of you, keep quiet—the next period starts in a few minutes,” he told the students, before walking out with Eric sir.

Shiva sat down in his seat, looking gently at Garima, who had dropped her head onto the bench.